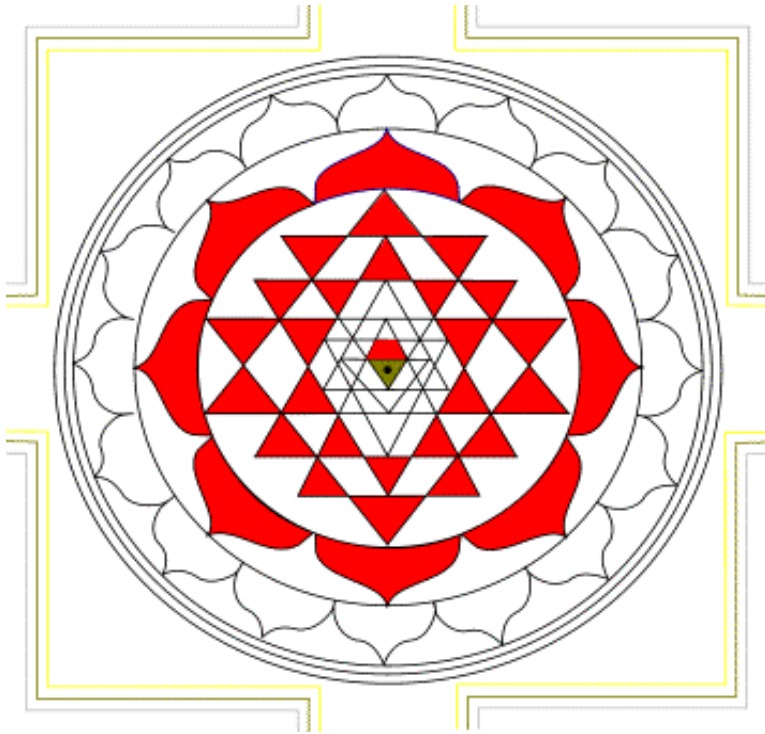




EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH

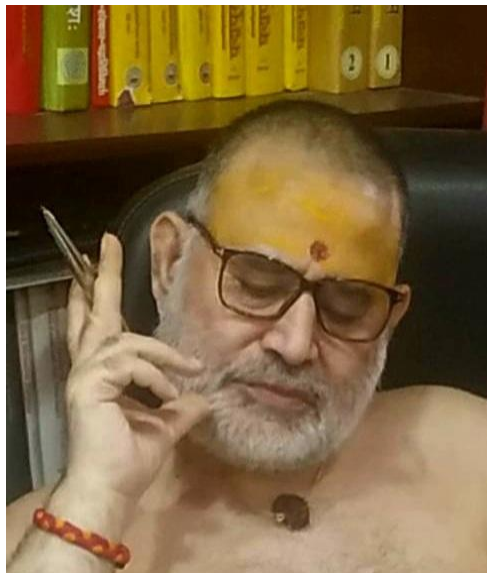
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RETROSPECTIVE

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Editorial

From the Chief Editor's desk 43

Fig seed, pod and the yolk of a peahen egg

The amalgam of word and meaning in the pashyanti mode of speech or is within or without, or every where, mused Somanand Nath a mystic thinker, in his *Shiv Drishti* *.



*पश्यंतीकिशरीरितः बहिर्षवत्र वा स्थिताः

अंतरव्यापितातस्यबाह्येकिमद्यमादिना। शि.दृ. २।४१

Shaivite monism explains word and meaning relation in a slightly unconventional manner. Unconventional from the perspective of a purist grammarian. Despite

Somanand's difference and deference with grammarian monism of shabda brahma Advait ,the first exponent of shavite advaita which later came to be called ishwaradwait ,the thematic difference is nominal and that too from a methodological stand point . The method given in vijñan bhairva **for a direct intuitive experience of the transcendental paravak is a meditation on the mind set which lies between total dreamless sleep and cessation of dream and exterior waking perceptions.

अनागतानिद्रायां प्रणष्टे बाह्यगोचरे

सावस्थामनस्थासनसागम्या परादेवीप्रकाशते वि.भै.

Like a huge tree latent in a fig seed the entire universal phenomena remains dormant in the seed of Shakti this specifies the disposition of paravak which is ever in unison with Parameshwara . All collective forms and names are veiled like beans in the pod of a legume this is the mediating mode of speech called pashyanti, since in this stage word and meaning are just about to separate . it is a intellectual prelude to actual expression . The yolk of an egg which contains the entire organs of a peacock latent in it ,is the best analogy of the unmanifest chaos which is impregnated with the essence of entire universal phenomena. This analogy defines Madhyama mode of vak as interior and the same as exterior ,is an intellectual prelude to actual expression I.e. audible speech .

There are these three analogies to help an aspirant get an idea of how the word meaning relation is experienced in various modes of speech . The divine origin theory of linguistics and the concept of a living word was first conceived of in the eastern mysticism . The eternal word conditioned as conceived idea and audible word is explained as ahamarth or the subjective pronoun which abbreviates all Sanskrit alphabet denoting the word as well the corresponding tatwas denoting the meaning part of the phenomena . Vowels being shiva and consonants the remaining 35 tatwas. This signifies all expressions and the substantial essence as pervaded by the universal substratum. There have been extraneous postulations of word meaning in occidental traditions. There is a similar Semitic concept “in the beginning “there was word and the word was God” but the word in this parlance is Jehovaha and the God it pertains to is the occidental God i.e. Creator who stays at a distance from his creation I.e. He doesn't pervade it after creating .

“Aham” on the other hand is the super ego or essential nature of the entire universe- comprises the very substratum, the word Aham which as a noted mystic defines as the “eternal Roar of Bhairav” whenever united with Vimarsha or self evident consolidates and while descending to grosser manifestations modifies into Para or the transcendental chaos . This mode of awareness is analogous to a leguminous pod where word and meaning at various levels of manifestation are arranged but concealed within it.

In a grosser relevance or Madhyama which literally means “lying in between” the entire universal phenomena lies dormant like a peacock in the yolk of an egg. The ever reciprocating sequence of the word and meaning manifest as the entire universe made from name and form is imbibed in a three dimensional minuscule of time, space and substance. This “seed of Shakti” lies in the twilight zone of transcendence from where the conscious , and subjective substratum appears to pervade, transcend as well as transcend and pervade both.

विश्वोत्तीर्णाविश्वमयीं स्वसंविदं नौमि।

I bow down to “the gnosis of my very self who pervades the universe and transcends it simultaneously” .

Within the pale of tantricism there are three corollaries each maintaining pervasive , transcendent or simultaneously pervasive and transcendent aspect of creator and creator relationship .

The fourth audible or expressible word which is distinctly separate from its meaning is the universal manifestation of the universe .वैखरीविश्वविग्रहा।

Ancient seers conceptualised the universal phenomena as “expression” in the form of name and form -word and meaning . To speak in the lingo of ancient tantricism as nada and Bindu or the conjugal of shiva and Shakti.

*पश्यंतीकिंशरीरितः बहिर्सर्वत्र वा स्थिताः अंतरव्यापिता तस्य बाह्ये किमध्यमादिना। शि.दृ. २।४१

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Editorial



The pursuit of creativity and playfulness in its deepest form is the journey of the self trying to fathom its own mysteries. The moment one goes beyond seeing creative endeavors as simply entertainment or objects of display they reveal their true nature as projections of the grand divine play and a powerful tool for self realization. A person who is able to see the past and foresee the future by being completely immersed in present moment is termed as a ‘genius’ by Aristotle. One who can see the full blown oak tree by just looking at the acorn and imagining the blue print inside it.

Here one is reminded of the the wonderful pen picture of Acarya Abhinavagupta by his extremely devoted and creative follower, Madhuraja. The painting based on the literal translation of the poetic rendition has fixed a certain kingly image of the master in our minds. The question really is did Madhuraja actually saw the paraphernalia or was his intense devotion and imagination at work where he visualized his master’s grandeur in material terms and the bliss of Bhairava in the luxury of the kingly state.

Explaining the idea we begin with the insightful editorial by our Guru Maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirth ji on the notion of the mystic view of the relation between word and meaning. “Like a huge tree latent in a fig seed the entire universal phenomena remains dormant in the seed of Shakti this specifies the disposition of paravak which is ever in unison with Parameshwara” writes Swamiji.

In this Retrospective issue we present a cross-section of various erudite and enlightening write-ups by scholars, seekers and mystics from various parts of the world. We hope it will strike a chord with the readers.

We begin with an enlightening article by Prof Subhash Kak on ‘Art and Cosmology in India’ . According to him the best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. He stresses that textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

‘Qunitessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of Sri Abhinavagupta’s Paramathsara’ is the title of an erudite article by Dr. Jeffrey S. Lidke. In this essay, author has attempted to illuminate how the Paramathsara, a seminal text by Abhinavagupta serves as a guide for the process of the awakening and internal ascension of kundalini-sakti.

An experiential piece on the essence of Nada‘ by Suva, a multidisciplinary artist gives a thorough insight in sound systems and the impact they create in our lives. Many scholars have already interpreted words and notations of sound in myriad textual frames. Suva illustrates more on the essence of sound that touched him through his visual, performative and performance practice in the various phases of his artistic growth. Following this we have an engaging article on ‘Naropa, Kalchakra and Nalanda tradition’ by Niraj Kumar raising important questions about both the factual as well as philosophical roots of the tradition. Next we have a scholarly and informative article on ‘The sun temple at Modhera’ by Dr. Advaitavadini Kaul which touches upon the history, architecture and the etymology associated with the said structure.

This is followed by a thought provoking introduction to the concepts of Indian aesthetics by a stalwart of literary, philosophical and cultural studies, Dr. S.S Toshkhani. Starting from Bharata’s Natyashastra and Rasa-Sutra it goes on to explore various commentaries on Rasa-Sutra by Sri Shankuka, Bhatta Kallata, Bhatta Tauta and so on. An analysis of the eternity of the elements of semantic relationship in the context of the Triakagama text of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta’ is the title of the next academic paper by Shivananda Behera where he systematically

explores the notion of word, meaning and the relation between them from an esoteric perspective

Coming next we have an interesting academic write-up by Bhoomi Sati on 'Measuring Meditational Trance' where she explores the ways in which the impact of yoga and meditation on brain can be measured scientifically and hence also be calculated.

We also have some open ended and bold poems by the Russian poet Andrei Azsacra bordering on Shunyavada. The transmodern Nihilism is evident in most of his poems which are also a slap on the existing political and administrative systems.

Swamiji's insightful conversations with Dr. Sisir Roy on the nature of vibration and quantum vacuum, a notion that has been engaging and intriguing modern day scientists follows next. The questions raised by the latter have been succinctly answered by Swamiji citing relevant examples wherever necessary. The concepts that quantum physics is dealing with have been contemplated upon by hoary seers and given due importance in their writings. Some of these notions like Spanda, Maatrisva and Chidakasha have been discussed in these extremely perceptive and discerning correspondences.

This is followed by a poem by Ambika Talwar full of spritiual quest and longing. 'Sacred lodge for Beloveds' would remind one of mystic love poetry written by various poets who have given words to their eternal longing.



Kimiya



A hymn to Buddhist Mahakal -the god of terror and fury

MAHAKALA STOTRAM



MAHAKAL THE PERSONIFICATION OF ABSOLUTE TIME

व्याघ्रचर्माम्बरधरं महाक्रोधस्वरूपिणम्।

द्वादशादित्यसंकाशं महाकालं नमोजस्तु ते॥ ५॥

O mahakala obeisance to you. Your effulgence resembles that of the twelve suns, you wear a tiger hide and are the embodiment of absolute wrath.

Mystery of a tiger hide

Mahakala as an embodiment of shiva is draped in a tiger hide . In all other sects where shiva is worshiped as an ascetic the tiger hide as attire and cushion are common-place . An ascetic once told me that as a yogi sits in meditation in deep thickets seated on a tiger hide, serpents and scorpions cannot creep on his body and being smeared in holy ashes make him immune to mosquitoes and mites and thus his trance of yogic bliss is not disturbed. Mahakala also being a form of aghor ascetic remains draped in a tiger hide. In vajrayana semiotics a tiger denotes pride or to be more precise the false pride a mortal

has in ephemeral possessions and attributes -wealth, beauty, physical prowess so on and so forth.

This mystic semiotics is very complex and at times besides enunciating the qualities of the deity also have the means ends and accomplishments of adorations rolled in the appearance of a deity .

A yogi desirous of time transcendence through meditation upon 'kala or absolute time must discard his identification with all that lies within the domain of relative time e.g false ideation leading to pride which in fact is a misgiving causing transitory and ephemeral and transitory as eternal. Pride comes from the innate misidentification with the transitory or perishable mistaken as eternal. Charnel grounds or shamshana is another method of getting over this misconception .There are eight shmashanas in tantric canons of both swachhanda tantra.

as well as Tibetan vajrayana . Their esoteric explanation is the eternal shunya which pervades the eight fold nature . In kali kula[the sect devoted to worship of goddess kali] region between the eyebrows is called the cemetery because by meditating upon this plexus - one transcends identification with both gross as well as subtle body.

As displayed in most of Mahakala relics the corpse under Mahakal's feet is in fact Buddha. The conspicuous figurine of Buddha under Mahakala's feet is in fact the corpse of Buddha, suggesting that even Buddha in his corporeal manifestation, the perfectly enlightened one is also within the domain of relative time and thus inferior to Mahakala or the personification of absolute time. According to Srilankan school of Hinayana there have been

24000 Buddhas so far. Hindus maintain that the Buddha is the ninth incarnation of Vishnu and this frequents in every cycle of four yugas -as the eon of darkness begins i.e. in Kali Yuga . The running eon is the twenty eighth cycle so in one day of brahma there have been one thousand Buddhas. This frequents constantly till brahma is hundred years

old and finally merges into his essential nature beyond the unmanifest . All this is decreed by the prowess of Mahakal . Mahakal tramples the past Buddha under his feet and makes space for the consequent one to manifest .Gautama the preceding one is ousted by Mahakal and the following one i.e. matreya Buddha will replace him. This cycle is perpetuated till and man attains Buddha hood and is enlightened. Mahakala is the agency which carries out this phenomenon. Every enlightened man is Buddha says a zen koan but the instant of epiphany is governed by Mahakal or time as a conscious entity. Pride 'the lion' is skinned by the furious Mahakal and drapes himself in its hide.

Krodhas and mahakrodha .

All wrath gods and goddesses are portrayed. Panic and terror has played a crucial role in the propagation of faith specially when the faith has no concrete substratum of philosophical conviction . Especially when faith has to be propagated among rustic and naive savages. For them the hall mark of greatness is according to their own disposition. A more violent aggressive and ferocious entity is their god almighty. Wrath or fury has been the most peculiar depiction of god when he has to be preached to -aggressive and belligerent pagans . The wrathful Brahman of taitireya upanisad coaxes - winds, fire ,the sun and even death to carry out the tasks assigned to them. Only an enlightened soul

says the canon will not be scared आनंदं ब्रह्मणो विद्वान् न विभेति कुतश्चना 'a knower of the bliss of brahma dreads no one' . The wrathful profile of Mahakala also indicates that till you are enlightened you are prone to my tyranny. There are ten krodhas in vajrayana

1 Yamantak, 2 Prajnantaka 3 Padmantaka, 4 Vighnantak 5 Achala 6 Takkiraj 7 Nildanda 8 Mahabala 9 Ushnish chakravaarti and 10 Sambharaja. These are the ten krodhas worshiped on the peripheries of all mandalas. Nispanna yogavali has the details of drawing their thankas, mantras and method of worship. Mahakal the great wrath is the eleventh one who not only supersedes them but also commands them as his subordinates. These are considered as the deities residing in the ten quarters , including up and down. Antaka is the slayer or terminator . These are merely Krodhas but Mahakala who commands them is mahakrodhaswroopi the personification of great wrath.

Indian astrology attributes one 'sun ' to each Rashi or zodiac they are called

From a mystic stand point they are seated in the twelve petals of the anahata chakra in the microcosm . All these are not only motivated but also illuminated by the single entity whose effulgent nature surpasses all these twelve Adityas, hence bearing the effulgence of twelve Adityas . These are also meditated upon by hath yogis as the ten vital airs or pranas namely -prana, apana, vyana, udana, saman, nag, kurma, krikala, Devdutt and dhanajya the remaining two I.e. aquarium and pieces signify jiva and paramatma. Vatul Nath sutra attributes these to five senses of knowledge and five organs of action including mind and intellect . So esoteric Mahakala or the essential nature governs and controls these.

The Hindu shrine of Mahakala in Ujjayini is also related to this phenomena by some ancient thinkers . Mahakala who is worshipped in the form of a shiva relic is actually the one who decrees all twelve suns through their respective zodiacs while himself remaining beyond them and hence the great absolute time .

Twelve zodiacs and nidanas of pratitya samutpada -

Kalachakra tantra relates these zodiacs to the twelve nidanas of Pratitya samutpada -''dependent origination ''in kalachakra tantra the first zodiac is -

Makara or Capricorn which is related to the first nidanas I.e.avidya so on and so forth . Following is the list of of zodiacs and their respective nidanas

Paratparswarup varni

Makara is avidya,

Kumbh is sansakara

To be contd

Meen is ,vijnana,

Mesha is Nama Rupa,

Vrishabha is Sadayatna (six senses)

Mithuna is sparsha'

Karka is Vedna

Simha is Trishna

Kanya is upadana

Tula is Bhava,

Vrishchik is jati,

Dhanu is Jaramarana,

Mahakala as the controller of these nidanas of dependent origination must be beyond these so in a figurative way he has been facilitated as ''the one bearing a hue of twelve suns'' Obeisance to Mahakal starts with initiation in the cult of the wheel of time . Then physical adorations comprising the offering of sandalpaste,flowers, incense, lamp and food. This is usually accompanied by psalmodising ,recital of various hymns and psalms related with Mahakala. finally comes the esoteric and meditation part of it

*Swachhanda tantra .

Art and Cosmology in India



Prof. Subhash Kak

The best way to understand India is through its art and the cosmology. Textbook narratives often overlook the synthesizing principles that represent the grammar of Indian culture, and they are much like the accounts of the six blind people who encountering an elephant describe it as wall, spear, snake, tree, rope, and fan, respectively.

The three notions that underlie Indian culture are that of bandhu, paroksa, and yajña. Bandhu is the binding between the outer and the inner that makes it possible to know, and this is the basis of the pervasive spirituality in India; paroksa is the recognition that the bandhu must lie outside of rational system, leading to the distinction between the 'higher' science of consciousness and the 'lower', rational objective science; yajña is transformation that the individual undergoes by participating in Vedic 'ritual' or any other creative process. The cosmology related to this framework is that of infinity and recursion across scale and time.

Figure 1. Sri Yantra, which represents the universe recursively

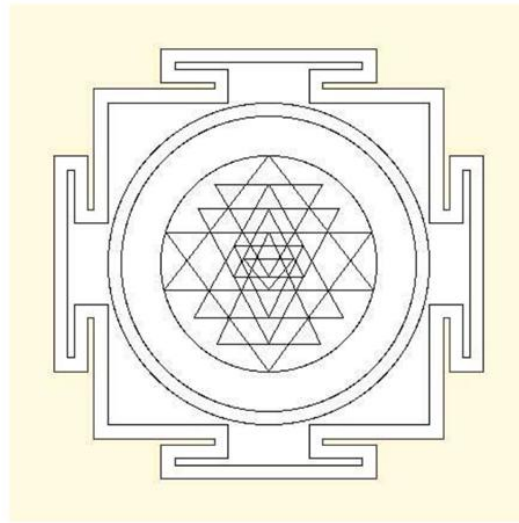


Figure 1. Sri Yantra, which represents the universe recursively

The iconic representation of the universe as the Sri Yantra (Figure 1) shows recursion most clearly. First, the tripartite division into earth, atmosphere, and the sun, which is mirrored in the individual by the body, the breath, and the inner lamp of consciousness, is represented by three triangles. Second, within each triangle are lower hierarchical levels of two other triangles, of alternating opposing polarity that represents male and female principles. All together, this adds up to 9 triangles, which through their overlaps constitute a total of 43 small triangles. Right through the middle of this is the dot, the bindu that is Shiva, the Witness, or Consciousness. Nature evolves according to law (rta in Sanskrit), but it has a paradoxical relationship with the consciousness principle.

Art associated with this conception must communicate recursion, paradox and oppositions concerning ordinary experience of the universe. Aesthetics, as a philosophy of art, is best understood from the point of view of dhvani, which communicates, by suggestion, the universals of the outer and inner worlds. Indian thought highlights the connections between these two worlds, and

its art presents visions of the cosmos. Thus in Figure 2, a north Indian temple, recursion is expressed in terms of the tower drawn to different scales on the superstructure.



Figure 2. A north Indian temple showing recursion in its outer structural form

Within the temple, the manifestations of the Supreme Being are as the One and its many forms. There exists in them, for example, a hierarchical order of cardinal and peripheral images in relation to the centre, a balancing or pairing of polarities, and representation of the temple as Mount Meru, the centre of the universe. The polarities represented iconographically related to female and male, asura (demon) and deva (god), left and right, body and mind, and so on. Aesthetics is alamkara shastra, that is ornamentation of the central synthesizing principle by means of the particular medium. The poet, kavi, is the inspired seer who sees the underlying vision most clearly. Dance, painting, and sculpture, just like poetry, have their canonical ideals, which are the visual equivalents of meter, rhyme, alliteration and the tropes of poetry.

The ritual is organized as sacred theatre that engages the senses to facilitate an epiphany that represents an experiential 'rebirth'. Great art has the same capacity, and often it is a part of ritual. Not only is the temple a work of art, so is the sculpture that goes into it, and the dance and music performed in its hallways, and the paintings that hang on its walls. One can contrast this with Western conceptions. The cosmology is finite, with God separate from the individual; art is best seen in the sterile atmosphere of the museum or the gallery.

General equivalences

The view that the arts belong to the domain of the sacred and that there is a connection between them is given most clearly in a famous passage in the Vishnudharmottara Purana in which the sage Markandeya instructs the king Vajra in the art of sculpture, teaching that to learn it one must first learn painting, dance, and music:

Vajra: How should I make the forms of gods so that the image may always manifest the deity?

Markandeya: He who does not know the canon of painting (citra-sutra) can never know the canon of image-making (pratima lakshana).

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of painting as one who knows the canon of painting knows the canon of image-making.

Markandeya: It is very difficult to know the canon of painting without the canon of dance (nritta shastra), for in both the world is to be represented.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of dance and then you will speak about the canon of painting, for one who knows the practice of the canon of dance knows painting.

Markandeya: Dance is difficult to understand by one who is not acquainted with instrumental music (atodya).

Vajra: Speak about instrumental music and then you will speak about the canon of dance, because when the instrumental music is properly understood, one understands dance.

Markandeya: Without vocal music (gita) it

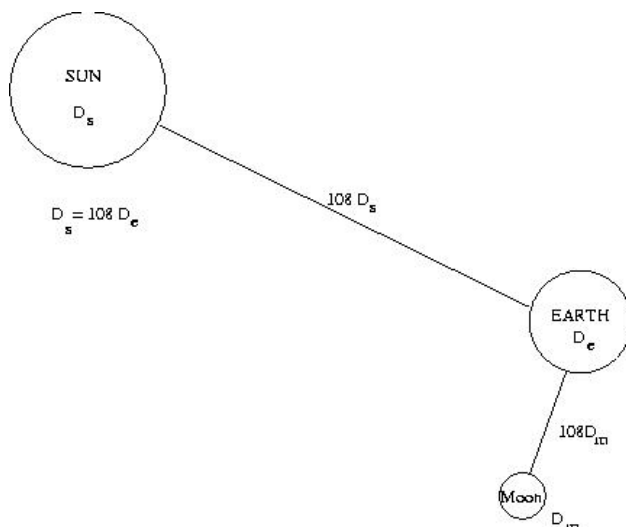
is not possible to know instrumental music.

Vajra: Explain to me the canon of vocal music, because he, who knows the canon of vocal music, is the best of men who knows everything.

Markandeya: Vocal music is to be understood as subject to recitation that may be done in two ways, prose (gadya) and verse (padya). Verse is in many meters. Some of the early meters range from the gayatri with 3 sections of 8 syllables ($3 \times 8 = 24$) to anushtubh ($4 \times 8 = 32$), viraj ($4 \times 10 = 40$), trishtubh ($4 \times 11 = 44$), and jagati ($4 \times 12 = 48$). These appear to be connected to the astronomical number 360, the number of civil days in the year. There are also many other more complex meters, with a less obvious astronomical basis.

To understand the principle behind the broader equivalences of Indian art and its cosmology, it is good to begin with the fire altars of the Vedic period that were themselves designed to represent astronomical (outer) as well as inner knowledge. An assumed equivalence between the outer and the inner cosmos is central to the conception of the temple, which is why numbers such as 108 and 360 are important in its design.

Figure 3. The number 108 in the distance from the earth to the sun and the moon



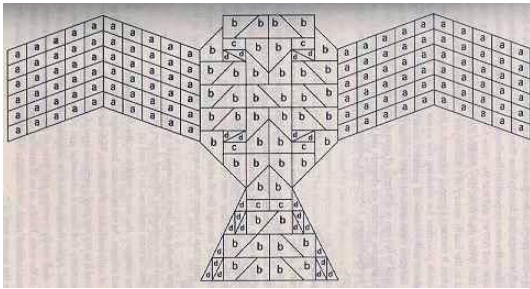
The number 108 represents the approximate distance from the earth to the sun and the

moon in sun and moon diameters, respectively. (The diameter of the sun is also 108 times the diameter of the earth, but that fact is not likely to have been known to the Vedic rishis.) This number of dance poses (karanas) given in the Natya Shastra is also 108, as is the number of beads in a rosary (japamala). The 'distance' between the body and the inner sun is also taken to be 108, so that the number of joinings is 107. Not surprisingly, the number of marmas in Ayurveda is 107. The total number of syllables in the Rigveda is taken to be 432,000, a number related to 108. The number 360 is taken in the Ayurvedic texts to be the number of bones in the developing fetus, a number that fuses later into the 206 bones of the adult. The centrality of this number in Vedic ritual is stressed in the Shatapatha Brahmana.

The primary Vedic number is three, representing the tripartite division of the physical world into the earth, the atmosphere, and the sky and that of the person into the physical body, the pranas, and the inner sky. The Vedic altars had an astronomical basis related to the reconciliation of the lunar and solar years, which mirrors the reconciliation of the female and male currents within the body and mind of the individual. The fire altars symbolized the universe and there were three types of altars representing the earth, the space and the sky. The altar for the earth was drawn as circular, whereas the sky (or heaven) altar was drawn as square. The fire altars were surrounded by 360 enclosing stones, of these 21 were around the earth altar, 78 around the space altar and 261 around the sky altar. In other words, the earth, the space, and the sky are symbolically assigned the numbers 21, 78, and 261. Considering the earth/cosmos dichotomy, the two numbers are 21 and 339 since cosmos includes the space and the sky.

The main altar was built in five layers. The basic square shape was modified to several forms, such as falcon and turtle. These altars were built in five layers, of a thousand bricks

of specified shapes. The construction of these altars required the solution to several geometric and algebraic problems. Two different kinds of bricks were used: the special and the ordinary. The total number of the special bricks used was 396, explained as 360 days of the year and the additional 36 days of the intercalary month. Two kinds of day counts: the solar day, and tithi, whose mean value is the lunar year divided into 360 parts.



Three different years were considered: (i) nakshatra, or a year of 324 days (sometimes 324 tithis) obtained by considering 12 months of 27 days each, where this 27 is the ideal number of days in a lunar month; (ii) lunar, which is a fraction more than 354 days (360 tithis); and (iii) solar, which is in excess of 365 days (between 371 and 372 tithis). A well-known altar ritual says that altars should be constructed in a sequence of 95, with progressively increasing areas. The increase in the area, by one unit yearly, in building progressively larger fire altars is 48 tithis which is about equal to the intercalation required to make the nakshatra year in tithis equal to the solar year in tithis. But there is a residual excess which in 95 years adds up to 89 tithis; it appears that after this period such a correction was made. The 95 year cycle corresponds to the tropical year being equal to 365.24675 days. The cycles needed to harmonize various motions led to the concept of increasing periods and world ages.

The number of syllables in the Rigveda confirms the textual references that the book was to represent a symbolic altar. According to various early texts, the number of syllables

in the Rigveda is 432,000, which is the number of muhurtas in forty years. In reality the syllable count is somewhat less because certain syllables are supposed to be left unspoken. The organization of the Rigveda is also according to a plan, but that is a different story told in my book *The Astronomical Code of the Rigveda*. The verse count of the Rigveda can be viewed as the number of sky days in forty years or $261 \times 40 = 10,440$, and the verse count of all the Vedas is $261 \times 78 = 20,358$.

The Brahmanas and the Shulbasutras tell us about the altar of chhandas and meters, so we would expect that the total Rigvedic hymn count of 1017 and the group count of 216 have particular significance. Owing to the pervasive tripartite ideology of the Vedic books we choose to view the hymn number as 339×3 . The tripartite ideology refers to the consideration of time in three divisions of past, present, and future and the consideration of space in the three divisions of the northern celestial hemisphere, the plane that is at right angle to the earth's axis, and the southern celestial hemisphere. The number 339 is simply the number of disks of the sun or the moon to measure the path across the sky: π times 108 is approximately 339. The Rigvedic code then expresses a fundamental connection between the numbers 339 and 108. The numbers 108 and 360 appear as the axis and the perimeter dimensions of the temple.

Temples and gods

The temple is considered in the image of the Cosmic Purusha, on whose body is displayed all creation in its materiality and movement. Paradoxically, the space of the Purusha (Rigveda 10.90) is in the sanctuary only ten fingers wide, although he pervades the earth. The outer cosmos is expressed in terms of various connections between the temple structure and the motions of the sun, the moon, and the planets; the inner cosmos is represented in terms of the divinity (universal consciousness) in the womb of the temple and various levels of the superstructure that correspond to the states of consciousness. The

position of the gods in the Vastupurusha-mandala within the temple is a symbolic representation of the spatial projections of the cosmic Purusha in his body. There are other iconic representations of sacred space, as in the Sri Yantra where the body's three parts – vagbhava, madhya, and mula – have recursive structures within, that represent Vedic cosmology in a unique fashion. The prototype of the temple is the Agnikshetra, the sacred ground on which the Vedic altars are built. The Agnikshetra is an oblong or trapezoidal area on which the fire altars are built. During the ritual is installed a golden disc (rukma) with 21 knobs or hangings representing the sun with a golden image of the purusha on it. The detailed ritual includes components that would now be termed Shaivite, Vaishnava, or Shakta. In Nachiketa Agni, 21 bricks of gold are placed one top of the other in a form of shivalinga. The disk of the rukma, which is placed in the navel of the altar on a lotus leaf is in correspondence to the lotus emanating from Vishnu's navel which holds the universe. Several bricks are named after goddesses, such as the seven krittikas.

Figure 5. Ganesha: elephant-headed, mouse as his vehicle



The Hindu temple represents the Meru mountain, the navel of the earth. It is the

representation of the cosmos both at the level of the universe and the individual, making it possible for the devotee to get inspired to achieve his own spiritual transformation. The purusha placed within the brick structure of the altar represents the consciousness principle within the individual. It is like the relic within the stupa. The threshold to the inner sanctum is represented by the figure of Ganesha (Figure 5), who, like other divinities, symbolizes the transcendence of oppositions.

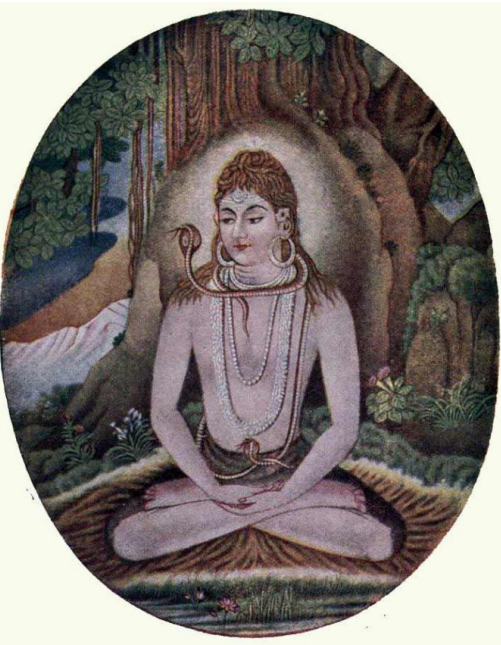
The temple construction begins with the Vastupurusha mandala, which is a yantra, mostly divided into 64 (8×8) or 81 (9×9) squares, which are the seats of 45 divinities. Brahma is at the centre, around him 12 squares represent the Adityas, and in the outer circle are 28 squares that represent the nakshatras. This mandala with its border is the place where the motions of the sun and the moon and the planets are reconciled. It is the Vastu in which the decrepit, old Chyavana of the Rigveda 1.116.10 asks his sons to put him down so that he would become young again. Chyavana is the moon and Sukanya, whom he desires, is the sun.

In the basic Vedic scheme the circle represents the earth and the square represents the heavens or the deity. But the altar or the temple, as a representation of the dynamism of the universe, requires a breaking of the symmetry of the square. As seen clearly in the agnichayana and other altar constructions, this is done in a variety of ways. Although the main altar might be square or its derivative, the overall sacred area is taken to be a departure from this shape. In particular, the temples to the goddess are drawn on a rectangular plan. In Shiva or Vishnu temples, which are square, change is represented by a play of diagonal lines. These diagonals are essentially kinetic and are therefore representative of movement and stress. They embody the time-factor in a composition.

The Hindu temple, as a conception of the astronomical frame of the universe, serves

the same purpose as the Vedic altar, which reconciled the motions of the sun and the moon. The progressive complexity of the classical temple was inevitable given an attempt to bring in the cycles of the planets and other ideas of the yugas into the scheme. There was also further complexity related to the expansion of the tattvas within the temple. For example, in Shaivite temples we see the unmanifest (Shivalinga) expand into the intermediate state of manifest-unmanifest (Sadashiva), and finally into manifest (Mahesha).

The Ashtadhyayi of Panini (5th century BC) mentions images. Ordinary images were called pratikriti and the images for worship were called archa. Amongst other things we are told that a toy horse is called ashvaka. (This means that the queen who lay down with the ashvaka in the Ashvamedha did not sleep with the dead horse.) Deity images for sale were called Shivaka etc., but an archa of Shiva was just called Shiva. Patanjali mentions Shiva and Skanda deities. There is also mention of the worship of Vasudeva (Krishna). We are also told that some images could be moved and some were immovable. Panini also says that an archa was not to be sold and that there were people (priests) who obtained their livelihood by taking care of it. They also mention temples that were called prasadas.



Complementing the tradition of the Vedic ritual was that of the munis and yogis who lived in caves and performed austerities. From this tradition arose the vihara, where the priests lived. The chaitya hall that also housed the stupa may be seen as a development out of the agnichayana tradition where within the brick structure of the altar was buried the rukma and the golden man.

The gods are the entities that hold up the inner sky of the mind. There is the single Brahman or Purusha, interpenetrating and transcending the inner and the outer universes. But the framework of the inner sky is held up by a variety of gods. The physical nature, governed by laws, is the Goddess or Shakti. If Brahma is the deity of the astral world, Shiva is that of the physical world, and Vishnu that of the causal or the moral world. They each have a consort:

Brahma's is Sarasvati, the goddess of learning and the arts; Shiva's is Parvati, the goddess of power, energy, and intuition; Vishnu's is Lakshmi, the goddess of good fortune.

The gods themselves are interconnected. Brahma's origin is from the lotus in Vishnu's navel. Shiva is the god who subsumes all oppositions. He is the celibate, divine yogi, who is also the perfect husband to Parvati. He brings the world to an end by his dance, but he also creates the world. He is the heart of consciousness, the lord of all beings, the divine dancer. As Ardhanarishvara, he is half Shakti; as Harihara, he is half Vishnu.

Vishnu is the all-pervader, the primal person, without beginning or end. He is also known as Narayana, with his abode in the waters. He is Hari, the golden-garbed one (like the Sun), and his mount is Garuda, the eagle. During the periods in between dissolution and creation, he sleeps on the cosmic serpent Ananta (the endless). He wields in one of his hands the discus, Sudarshana, which represents time. His consort, Lakshmi, appeared out of the Churning of the Ocean.

Periodically, he descends to earth as an avatara to battle evil. Two of the most popular of these avatars are Rama and Krishna.

Churning of the ocean

If extraordinary experience is an epiphany, it comes at the end of long preparation. In myth, we speak of the struggle between the asuras (demons) and the devas (gods), but this struggle also occurs within the individual between his materialistic and acquisitive tendencies that are demonic, and those of sacrifice, compassion, and understanding that are divine. This struggle is described as the churning of the ocean by the gods and the demons as in Figure 7. On the axis rests the Goddess, who represents Nature. Note that the demons are shown with animal faces since they represent our animal selves.

Our body sense is much stronger than the sense of spirit. It is for this reason the asuras are generally much stronger than the gods. The story goes that the gods have been defeated and they are dejected. At some point they go to Vishnu for help and he suggests that they should assist the asuras in the churning of the ocean of milk, out of which will appear the nectar of immortality that would help them subdue the asuras.



Figure 7: The churning of the ocean

The gods and the demons got together and started churning the ocean with the Mount Mandara as the axis and the snake Vasuki as the rope. The gods

were at Vasuki's tail while the demons were at his head. Vishnu appeared as a tortoise to support the revolving mountain. As the churning went on, many gifts appeared including the moon which Shiva decided to use as an ornament on his head. Next came Dhanvantari, carrying a jar full of nectar. Next arose Lakshmi, with her attendant elephants of the four quarters sitting on a lotus, a gift of the ocean. She went straight to Vishnu.

The demons were dismayed that Lakshmi had not come to them, and they stole the jar with the nectar that was in Dhanvantari's hands. But before they could drink it, Vishnu created an illusion of the most beautiful woman, Mohini, and they were so bewitched by her that they did not notice that she took the cup from their hands and gave them to the gods to drink. By the time they knew what had happened the gods had become immortal. The demons drew their weapons and attacked but it was useless. The gods once again became rulers of the three worlds.

Our body sense is much stronger than the sense of spirit. It is for this reason the asuras are generally much stronger than the gods. The asuric individual is doomed for he gets distracted by the illusory Mohini, whereas one who has higher ideals finds immortality and fame (Lakshmi).

Krishna's dance

Krishna's pranks and the love that the cowgirls (gopis) have for him is the frame for much of poetry, dance, and painting in India. As avatara of Vishnu, he is the narrator of the Vedic wisdom in the great dialogue of the Bhagavad Gita. His cowherd stories are a take-off on his other name Gopala, which means the protector of the world as well as cowherd, for the root gauh means both earth and cow.

The story of the love of the gopis is the story of each devotee for God. Krishna performs the rasa-lila, a dance, where mysteriously he is able to simultaneously dance with all the different gopis, which represents, no doubt the mystery that the same One is able to inhabit the many.

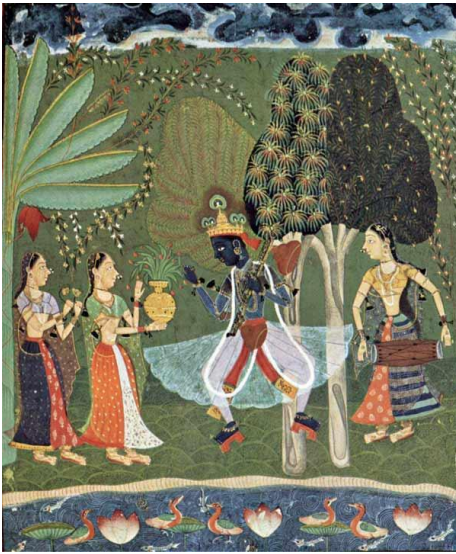


Figure 8: Dancing Krishna with his flute

Krishna, the flute player, is the spirit that inhabits each one of us. The flute is the body, and the melody is the unfolding of our individual lives. The love of Radha for Krishna can never be fulfilled, since the individual is forever doomed to stay apart from the divine in ordinary experience. In the Mahabharata, Dhritarashtra is the ego, Vidura is discriminating intelligence, the Kauravas are the physical desires, Krishna is the transcending atman, Arjuna is the empirical atman; the higher faculties are the Pandavas, and the lower faculties are the Kauravas. The characters of the epics and the Puranas do not only act in the outer world; they play out our own private battles.

In the Ramayana, Sita is the intuition who has been abducted by the demon within, who must be set free by Rama, the inner sun. The demon, representing the urge to dominate and possess, has ten heads that represent the sense and action organs of the body. In the struggle between the asuras and the gods, Hanuman, representing the human mind that has devotion, provides critical assistance.

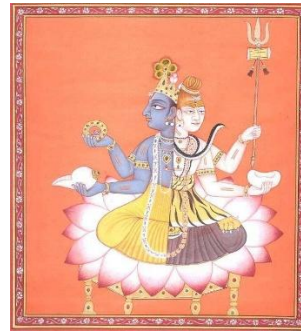


Figure 10. Harihara: Vishnu and Shiva as one

Although Vishnu and Shiva make their appearance generally in different situations since their centrality is in different domains, they are also visualized in a unity, as Harihara (Figure 10).

The Indian approach to reality is to seek a harmony that balances materiality with the spirit. It is this harmony that is the main goal of the artistic creation, and we see it expressed not only in the sacred arts, but also in music and dance.

The Indian aesthetic in an age of war

We live in an age of war fueled by conflicting visions of reality. The mainstream cultural view is of materialism in which consciousness is an emergent process and we are primarily nothing but our bodies. Perhaps because it belittles the spirit, it is leaving many young people with a sense of hopelessness. If there is nothing transcendent about life, then life may not be worth living. While some are choosing drugs or hedonism, others are rejecting rationality and joining cults. Religious leaders are stepping in with their own recipes to save the world from a soul-less hell. But their conceptions contradict each other, and although they rightly critique the materialistic paradigm for its disconnect with the spirit, they themselves remain focused on the body when they speak of everlasting life in paradise.

Because of the mechanization of life and the expectations raised by images with which we are bombarded by the media, many are choosing not to have a family, leading to a demographic crisis in the developed world at a time when the post-industrial service economy needs more workers and consumers, requiring vast numbers of immigrants from poorer countries. These are some of the elements leading to a clash of civilizations.

The Indian way offers a different perspective. Indian cosmology is not in conflict with science, although it does speak of the domain of spirit that lies beyond language and rational science. It makes claims regarding the nature of consciousness and transcendent states of awareness that are so extraordinary that if they should be validated by science, they would change the way we conceive of reality.

Our collective history in recent decades has tilted too much to material prosperity. The Indian way is not to reject the body, but to find a harmony between body and soul. To deal with the inevitable march of the machine and the dangers of totalitarianism of one sort or another, it provides intimations of other layers of being that lead to compassion and self-control. It opens up new vistas that shift the focus from being to becoming.

The Puranas have a charming story about how the gods came to become invincible, even though they started out as the weaker party. Shukra, the priest to the asuras, discovered, through science, the secret of reviving persons who had been killed in battle, and with this knowledge the asuras were able to subdue the gods. Brihaspati, who is the priest to the gods, recruited his son, Kacha, for obtaining this knowledge. Kacha presented himself to Shukra asking to be taken in as student. Even though he sensed danger in this, Shukra was helpless because one cannot turn away anyone who is seeking instruction.

Before long, Shukra's daughter Devayani fell in love with Kacha. The asuras were alarmed

and they killed him on two occasions, but on his daughter's pleadings Shukra revived him. The third time the asuras not only killed him, but ground his body into powder and mixed it with the wine that they offered to Shukra. When Devayani found that Kacha was missing, she pleaded with her father for help and with his powers he found what had really happened. But this time he could not just revive Kacha within his belly because that would cause his own death. He had to first teach him what the secret of restoring life was so that when revived, he would bring back the dead Shukra to life. This done, Kacha returned with the secret knowledge to the gods, who again became ascendant.

The coming together of spiritual India and mechanical modernity is like the coming together of Kacha and Shukra that can only be good for all mankind. With wisdom, it should be possible for people, irrespective of their cultural and social background, to live together with compassion and harmony in pursuit of a way of life that values freedom and personal creativity.

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Quintessence of the highest Purpose: A translation, introduction and analysis of SriAbhinavagupta's Paramarthsara



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Keywords: ābhāsa, Anuttara, kuṇḍalinī-śakti, Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, saḥāsrāra, satguru, tattva, Trika, twilight language.

Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.) is the greatest synthesizer of Indian Tantric thought and practice. His works influenced and shaped theoretical paradigms in the field of Indian aesthetics, Tantra, literature, and philosophy. In this paper, the author examines the 105 verses of Abhinavagupta's Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) in which Abhinavagupta articulates his philosophy of absolute monism, known popularly as Kashmir Śaivism. An earlier Paramārthasāra was composed by the South Indian legendary saint, Ādiśeṣa during the

sixth century, some four hundred years before Abhinavagupta. Abhinavagupta's reinvention of this older text indicates the constant transaction of ideas between Kashmir and South India, Vaiṣṇavite and Śaivite sects. The present shape of Indian thought emerged

only as a result of the fusion and appropriation of different thought-streams. A translation of the Paramārthasāra along with an introduction into Abhinavagupta's Monistic Śaivism has been herewith attempted.



The writings of the famous Tāntric guru and philosopher, Abhinavagupta (ca. 975-1025 C.E.), represent some of the finest reflections of Indian religio-philosophical thought. Of his many extant works, the Paramārthasāra (Quintessence of the Highest Purpose) offers a succinct distillation of Abhinavagupta's literary and philosophical genius while also encapsulating the system of esoteric practices at the heart of his Tāntric system. The one-hundred-and-five verses of this composite text lay out the śaivite vision of the universe as the unfolding of a unitary consciousness, called verily Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya, Cīṭ Śakti, and Anuttara. Through a process of hierarchical manifestation, this Supreme Principle assumes the form of thirty-six evolutes (tattvas), and in this way, projects the universe of diverse objects upon its own screen. At the core of

this universal projection, the absolute assumes the form of the limited human experiencer. Veiling itself with the three cloaks (trimala), Paramaśiva assumes self-limitation (saṅkocana). Yet, this contracted experience is only temporary. Through the awakening of coiled power (kuṇḍalinī-śakti) received in Tantric initiation (dīkṣā) the limited agent (kartā) internally ascends the ladder of tattvas and reclaims his status as the omnipotent Absolute.

In this essay, I have attempted to illuminate how the Paramārthasāra serves as a guide for this process of the awakening and internal ascension of kuṇḍalinī-śakti. Towards this end, I have rendered my own translation of the text and have written a brief introduction and commentary with the aim of framing for the reader the context in which Abhinavagupta penned his masterful text. In this way it is hoped that my essay serves as an introduction to both the text and the Trika-Kaula tradition in which it arises. By tracing the history of this tradition, and by analyzing its fusion of philosophy and practice in the context of tantric sādhana, I hope to provide an illuminating glimpse into one of the most gifted minds in the history of Indian civilization.

Contextualizing The Text

As a guide for this voyage into the uncharted realm of Tantric practice, we will follow the map drawn by Abhinavagupta in his condensed text, the Paramārthasāra (PS). In 105 ārya-ghaṭa verses, this cryptic and highly codified text details the fourfold path (upāya-catuṣṭayam) to realization (śivattva).

The first English rendering of this text appeared in 1910 in an article entitled “The Paramarthasara of Abhinavagupta” by L. D. Barnett.¹ In the preface to this outdated yet useful translation, Barnett writes that his intention in publishing the PS is part of a further

project in proving that the “living faith of the majority of modern Tamils is in almost every respect...the same doctrine that was taught in Kashmir about the beginning of the eleventh century by Abhinavagupta.”² This argument for a connection between southern and northern śaiva traditions is clearly strengthened by the fact that Abhinavagupta’s work is based on an earlier southern text of the same name.³ Interestingly, this sixth century text, also known as the Ādhārakārikā, is authored by a South Indian Vaiṣṇavite Guru, Ādiśeṣa, known more popularly as Patañjali, the legendary incarnation of Viṣṇu’s serpentine companion and the famous author of multiple important Sanskrit works. That Abhinavagupta based his 10th-century śaiva text on this early work suggests not only that there was a shared corpus of texts between the North and South, but also a shared philosophical and practical basis among the numerous traditions then present in Kashmir.

As Silburn points out, this unifying basis was the Sāṃkhya -Yoga system. Ādiśeṣa’s PS is essentially a Sāṃkhya text overlaid with Vaiṣṇava theology. It borrows the classic Sāṃkhya dualism of contentless consciousness (puruṣa) and materiality (prakṛti), while reframing it in the context of Viśiṣṭādvaita.

The Trika-kaula as a Tradition of experience (anubhavasampradāya)

While Abhinavagupta’s PS is clearly an adaptation of this earlier text, we would be unwise to follow Chatterji’s lead in labeling it as “only the Ādhāra-Kārikās with a few alterations here and there.” In fact, only a quarter of Abhinavagupta’s 105 verses directly parallel the Ādiśeṣa text. The remaining three-quarters are an expression of Abhinavagupta’s own Trika-Kaula system and have no direct counterpart in the older text. For this reason Abhinavagupta states that his purpose is not simply to transcribe the Ādhārakārikās

verbatim, but to elucidate them in “accord with the tenets of Trika-śaiva philosophy.”⁴

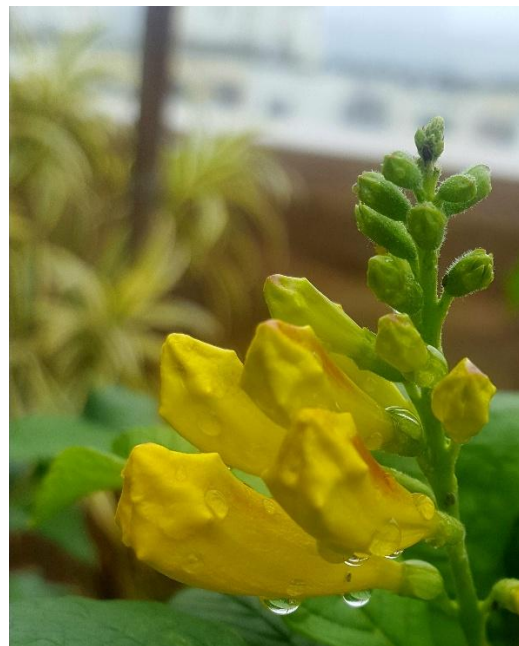
Interestingly, taking into account the frequent double intentionality of Tantric “twilight language” (sandhā-bhāṣā), this same verse can also be understood to mean that Abhinavagupta has written the PS “in accord with [his] yogic intuition of śaiva doctrine.” The crucial word in the text is *drṣṭi* (√*drś*, “to see”). Chatterji translates it as a synonym of *darśana*, or philosophical system,⁵ while Barnett renders it as “mystic vision.”⁶ Certainly, these are not mutually exclusive renderings, but rather equally valid and important translations of *drṣṭi*.⁷ Taken together, they reveal an essential feature of Indian philosophy: namely, its direct relation to direct experience (*anubhava*).⁸ In other words, in the context of Indian philosophizing, “spiritual vision” is often the logical precursor to a “philosophical system”; consequently, one’s own direct experience (*anubhava*) is a necessary and logical prerequisite to the writing of a philosophical treatise. Hence, we are to interpret Abhinavagupta’s use of the word “*drṣṭi*” as a conscious attempt to appropriate its polyvalency. In other words, his intention is to show that his capacity to elucidate the principles of śaiva philosophy (*darśana*) resides precisely in his own yogic perception (*drṣṭi*) attained through *sādhana*.

This interpretation would clearly be in line with Abhinavagupta’s own epistemological views that direct experience (*anubhava*) forms the apex of the three-fold means of correct knowledge (*pramāṇa*), whose base is scripture (*āgama*) and the word of the guru (*yukti*).⁹ Indeed, Abhinavagupta considers Tantra to be a “tradition based on experience” (*anubhavasampradāya*).¹⁰ Thus, the significance of the third verse of the PS is not only that it establishes the text’s relation to an older scripture, but, more importantly, the author’s own attainment.¹¹ For this reason,

Abhinavagupta’s Trika-Kaula deserves to be viewed not solely as fuel for the fires of philosophical abstraction (*tarkajvāla*), but rather as a practical system “providing a viable means for the attainment of *mokṣa*.”¹²

Abhinavagupta as *adhikārin*

In the final chapters of his *Tantrāloka*, Abhinavagupta narrates the special circumstances of his birth. Desiring to parent a *siddha*, or perfected being, Abhinavagupta’s parents—Narasimhagupta and Vimalā—performed an esoteric ritual. Consequently, when Abhinavagupta entered the world nine months later he was viewed not as an ordinary child, but as a *yoginībhū*, a special child conceived from the union of a *siddha* and a *yoginī* during the course of Tantric ritual. Due to the extraordinary circumstances of his birth and the rich devotional environs of his childhood, Abhinavagupta readily acquired mastery of a wide array of subjects ranging from Buddhist doctrine to śaiva Tantra, to grammar and poetry. However, according to Abhinavagupta, the apex and culmination of learning came through his “studies” with the Kaula guru, Śambhunāth. It was from this



teacher that Abhinavagupta received initiation into the esoteric Kula lineage. In this initiation he received the descent of power (śaktipāta) which produced a condition of embodied liberation (jīvan-mukta).¹³

Regardless of the authenticity of this autobiographical account, the fact that Abhinavagupta is compelled to narrate it in his magnum opus, the TĀ, suggests the prominent status of Tantric practice in his philosophical thought. As if compelled to justify his qualification for composing the TĀ, an authoritative synthesis of Tantric doctrine and practice, Abhinavagupta asserts that his authority lay in the very fact that he is quite simply a product of Tantra. Tantra is not something he learned solely from books, but is a practice that radically conditioned his birth and, later, produced his final enlightenment. In other words, in no uncertain terms Abhinavagupta is stating, “This doctrine is not simply something I have thought about; rather, it is a reality I have become.” Logically, then, his emphasis is not on providing intellectual stimulation, but on transmitting his own experience and knowledge (jñāna). For this reason, he states clearly that his duty as a teacher is to awaken his disciples.¹⁴

Ultimately, as Müller-Ortega, points out, Abhinavagupta’s teachings are to be seen as a method of realization leading to a state in which one “becomes something that moves in the Heart (hṛdayaṅgamībhūta)”.¹⁵ This state of inner absorption is something that, as Abhinavagupta himself points out, transcends the limits of language and for this reason the scholar attempting an

exegesis of the Trika-Kaula, is bound to confront an intriguing hermeneutical challenge. Addressing this matter Müller-Ortega asks rhetorically:

Can we completely hope to understand Abhinavagupta?...[In attempting to do so] [W]e immediately encounter an important and central cross-cultural perplexity. We have been using the term understand in its commonly accepted denotation: to have a thorough technical acquaintance with something. The term may be used in a stronger sense: Abhinavagupta distinguishes between an understanding that is purely intellectual, and one gained from experiential knowledge. There is an important sense in which to understand the Heart actually requires replicating the journey of return that is the tantric sādhana: we must play Śiva’s game to its most serious and hilarious conclusion, which is the unmasking of Śiva within ourselves.¹⁶

As Müller-Ortega himself points, this type of radical understanding challenges the traditional paradigms of western scholarship. Still, the scholar of Tantra ought not ignore the fact that much of Tantric thought stems from and is geared towards contemplative experiences. In other words, much of Tantric thought is properly classified as pertaining to the realms of spiritual practice and its concomitant experiences. Does this mean that we should accept Frits Staal’s bold assertion that to understand practice-based ritual traditions the scholar himself must learn the logic of its practice?¹⁷ Abhinavagupta’s unequivocal answer would be “yes”.

However, Abhinavagupta’s views would perhaps not fare well in the post-enlightenment environs of 21st-century academia. The deeply entrenched demand for scholarly distance and objectivity perhaps does not allow for the kind of full-bodied engagement that Abhinavagupta demanded of his own students.

However, the equally important demand for hermeneutical accuracy necessitates a proper contextualizing of Abhinavagupta's system. In other words, although as scholars we may feel duty-bound not to practice sādhanā, we are obligated nonetheless to be sensitive to the practice-based nuances of Abhinavagupta's densely coded writings.

This is not to say that pure philosophical inquiry has no place in the PS for such a statement would be far from the truth. Abhinavagupta's stature in Indian history is primarily due to his great gift for verbal expression. In a way unparalleled by any one prior to him, he was able to formalize the numerous esoteric streams of Tantra into a single, unified river of thought and practice. On this grand achievement Kamalakar Mishra writes:

Abhinavagupta presents the otherwise difficult philosophy of Tantra in a cogent and coherent way that makes the Tantric position logically and rationally acceptable. What is complex in Tantra becomes simple in his treatment; what is esoteric and mystical becomes rationally understandable.¹⁸

Abhinavagupta's cogent systematization stems from his own initiation and training in the various lineages and philosophical schools (sampradāya) of his time. In other words, Abhinavagupta's philosophy is not the product of a single line of thought; rather, it is a rich synthesis of the multiple indoctrinations he pursued during the years of his own sādhanā. In his person, the plethora of Tantric schools were united through the intensity of his own critical insight and fused into a single system in which the practices and philosophical views of the various schools were grouped as a hierarchy of ascending powers

culminating with the esoteric branch of Āgamic Tantrism known now as Trika-Kaula, "The Family of the Triad".¹⁹ And it was this ability to unify the plurality of Śaivism into a single doctrinal system that makes Abhinavagupta's work so intriguing. Before his time, there was no single tradition. Rather, as Alper has pointed out, there were only "a series of overlapping preceptorial lines, and a plenitude of spiritual techniques available to each teacher."²⁰ Hence, it was through Abhinavagupta's teachings that these numerous techniques and lineages were subsumed within a larger theoretical framework that embraced them all. And it is this carefully crafted framework that is now commonly referred to as Kashmir Śaivism.²¹ Although, historically speaking, there never was a Kashmir Śaivism, the fact that scholars now look at the traditions of Kashmir as a unified whole is due largely to Abhinavagupta (perhaps, then, the appropriate term would be "Abhinavagupta-ism"). For this reason no text better captures Abhinavagupta's gift-for-synthesis than the Paramārthasāra. A careful study of this brief yet dense text enables us to unpack the many levels of teachings and techniques he received and thereby appreciate the way in which he fuses them into a single Tantric "river".²²

This introduction to the PS is intended to guide the reader through the multiple initiatory streams that Abhinavagupta himself journeyed in the course of his sādhanā. In this way we can come to see that these streams-of-revealed-thought-and-practice were viewed by Abhinavagupta as ultimately united in a larger river-of-divine-consciousness that itself flows from and returns ever again into the infinite sea of radical freedom. The key to successfully charting this voyage lies in identifying the PS as a map for this most majestic of journeys. This text's purpose, as Abhinavagupta clearly states, is to guide the aspirant through the ascending levels of consciousness until there is the realization of one's identity with the Highest Purpose (paramārtha). It is along this route to the final destination that Tantric aspirant, or sādhanika, ontologically encounters the various philosophical systems as inner states of consciousness and being. In

other words, in the initial stages of sādhana, when one's consciousness is still mired by dualistic thought patterns (dvaitavikalpa), the teachings of the dualistic (dvaitāgama) are necessary. However, as one advances in sādhana, one's internal ascension is paralleled externally by initiation (dīkṣā) into scriptural traditions which claim to grant states of non-dual awareness. Hence, in the external world there is a plurality of teachings and spiritual techniques. Yet, in the inner life of the sādhanika these distinctions are fused in a process of internal bodily ascension.

To understand the mechanisms of this ascension we must first come to grips with the central philosophical systems embedded in the PS and the principle tenets that undergird Abhinavagupta's thought. Constructing these tenets as our boat, we will then be ready to explore the vast, mysterious waters of sādhanika that Abhinavagupta charts in the latter third of his treatise on the Quintessence of the Highest Purpose.

The Tantric Streams

Fourth stream appears to be fed not only by the Āgamas, but from sources ranging from Tamil Nādu in the South to Nepal in the North. This poly-sourced stream-of-revelation is the Kaula tradition with its emphasis on radical antinomian practices (called "left-handed", vāmācāra) as a means to immediate salvation. Of the many Kaula streams, there are two that flowed directly into Abhinavagupta's system: the goddess-centered cults of the Krama and the Trika. Apparently, Abhinavagupta experienced the Kaula waters as the most satisfying, for he claimed the Kaula to be the pinnacle of all traditions. And of the many streams that fed the Kaula system, he saw Trika as the greatest. In his words, Trika was to the Kaula as fragrance to a rose—its finest essence.²³ Hence,

Abhinavagupta proclaimed his philosophy to be Trika-Kaulism. As we have seen, this Trika-Kaula river results from the confluence not just of the Trika and Kaula, but from the Āgama, Pratyabhijñā, and Spanda streams as well.

Commencing The Journey into The highest purpose

The opening verse of the PS crystallizes the Trika śaivas' paradoxical conception of the Śiva, the Trika- Kaula Absolute. Here, Abhinavagupta honors Śiva as the "one without beginning" who "dwells manifoldly in secret places" as "the receptacle of all."²⁴ In other words, for the Kaśmirī Tāntrikas, the Absolute is simultaneously one and many. Endowed with unlimited power (śakti), the Supreme Principle can manifest itself infinitely without losing its essential unity. For this reason, the universe, though appearing divided, is really only the flashing forth (ābhāsa) of the One. Abhinavagupta writes (PS 4-5):

This sphere (aṇḍa, cosmic egg) ...is brought forth

by the Lord through the bestowal of his innate power and might. This universe with its succession of manifold bodies, organs and worlds is within these spheres; and therein is the enjoyer, the embodied Śiva who assumes the condition of creatures.

In other words Śiva contains within Himself the ability to manifest distinctions within unity (bhedābheda). Yet, just as a crystal remains untainted by the various hues it adopts, so the Absolute remains one despite its appearance in the form of "gods, humans, animals, and plant-life" (PS 6).

The process of universal manifestation is elaborately explained by the Trika system through the doctrine of the thirty-six evolutes or tattvas. The supreme reality—called Paramaśiva, Para Samvit, Caitanya—is pure consciousness beyond the sphere of manifestation. In reference to its transcendent-ness Abhinavagupta refers to the Absolute as the "thirty-

seventh tattva” in the TĀ.²⁵ Yet, this transcendent principle is also the ocean of consciousness out of which creation arises. For unlike the Vedāntin conception of Brahman as static consciousness, the Trika Śaiva absolute embodies both consciousness (caitanya) and dynamism or spanda-śakti. Acting as an inner pulse, the spanda-śakti unfolds the universe of tattvas within the body of the absolute (PS 10). Hence, in the Trika schema, the transcendent contains the manifest. And even during the time of cosmic manifestation, the supreme principle (para-tattva) remains “free of delusion, pure, peaceful and beyond creation and dissolution” (PS 11).

This capacity for internal self-manifestation is explained through a dialectic of illumination and reflection (prakāśa/vimarśa). Indeed, the Absolute is characterized as being endowed with these two principles (prakāśa-vimarśa-śakti). The Absolute embodies not only an illuminating consciousness, but also a reflective capacity for self-knowledge that plays out on all levels of manifestation. At the cosmogonic level, prakāśa is the first tattva, the śivatattva, and vimarśa is the second, the śaktitattva. These two, śiva and śakti, are understood to be the Lord (īśvara) and his consort, devī. In Tantric cosmogonic schemes the union of Śiva and Śakti gives rise to creation; and in a philosophical context the union of these two principles is the fusing of a knowing agent (pramātr) with the means of knowing (pramāṇa) which necessitates the need for a source of objective knowledge (prameya). Hence, in cosmogonic terms the prameya is the very universe itself, for the product of the union of śiva and śakti, prakāśa and vimarśa, pramātr and pramāṇa, is the additional thirty-four tattvas that form the basis of objective manifestation.

The key to understanding Trika-Kaula discourse is to realize that the prakāśa-vimarśa dialectic plays out at

all levels of reality. Another way to say this is that each of the lower tattvas incorporates within itself those tattvas that precede it. Hence, even the lowest tattvas, the elemental substances (pañca-mahābhūta), contain within themselves the essence of the tattvas from even the most subtle stages of creation. Hence, the principle of illumination (prakāśa) and self-reflection (vimarśa) are present at all levels of creation. In other words, all objects (prameyas) are constituted of prakāśa and vimarśa and for this reason Abhinavagupta claims that the knower, the means of knowing, and the object known comprise a triune Self. It is in this spirit that the Tantras state that there is nothing that is not Śiva.²⁶ Hence, the world itself, when properly understood becomes a basis for mystical realization. Indeed, the higher states of sādhana are said to consist in the awareness that the world itself is composed of the bliss experienced in yogic samādhi.²⁷ There is, in other words, no need to meditate in caves: the highest realization can just as easily be apprehended while doing such mundane things as sipping chai (Indian tea).

Abhinavagupta gives a potent metaphor for this extrovertive samādhi in his comparison of the relationship of the universe to the absolute with that of reflected images to a mirror:

Just as the images of a town, a village, and other objects reflected in a mirror appear inseparable from the mirror yet appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror, in the same way, arising from the absolute consciousness of Para Bhairava, this universe, though inherently void of divisions, nevertheless appears internally apportioned and distinct [from Para Bhairava] (PS 12-13).

In this multilayered metaphor there are three important elements: the objects (nagaragrāmādi), the reflections, and the mirror itself (darpaṇa). The relationship between them reveals both the fundamental principles of

prakāśa and vimarśa and the key to understanding śaiva yoga. The mirror itself is Śiva, or pure illumination (prakāśa). Possessing within itself the capacity for revelation (vimarśa), the mirror contains a variety of reflected images. In terms of epistemology, these images are the prameya. The fact of their reflection, which is the means of their

being perceived—hence known—, is the pramāṇa, and the mirror is the metaphorical knower (pramāṭṛ).

What is the relationship between the three? The answer to this question is more nuanced than it first appears. On a surface level, the reflected images appear distinct both from one another and from the mirror. In other words, according to conventional reality, one would consider the knower, the known, and means of knowing all distinct. However, as Abhinavagupta states, conventional understanding has no basis at the level of the Supreme Truth (PS 27). For this reason, the true relation of the three is stated to be one of inseparability (avibhāgin). Developing this theme of inseparability, Abhinavagupta goes on to equate the mirror with the absolute consciousness of highest Bhairava (vimalatama-parama-bhairava-bodham) who, both in terms of the metaphor and Trika cosmology, is the supreme knower (pramāṭṛ).

Now, what is the relationship between Bhairava and the universe? Abhinavagupta answers that despite the appearance of being mutually apportioned and distinct (vibhaktamābhāti), the relationship of Bhairava (pramāṭṛ) to the universe (prameya) and its reflection (pramāṇa)—like that of the mirror to its objects—is one void of distinctions

(vibhāgaśūnyam). In other words, from the highest perspective, the trinity of epistemological and cosmological principles is a unity. Like the various forms of candy, which are but modifications of syrup, these three are but modifications of the Supreme Self (PS 26).

This limited soul is the twelfth principle, the puruṣa- tattva. In verse sixteen Abhinavagupta refers to the puruṣa as a “fettered beast” who, due to the influence of māyā, has contracted from the condition of pure consciousness (bodham) to that of a tainted soul (malinas). At this level of the cosmic hierarchy, the Supreme Self, “due to its associations with the darkness of ignorance comes to perceive Itself as a wondrous diversity of subjects and objects.” In other words, at the level of the puruṣa-tattva, there is a perceived split between self and other.

And at this stage there unfolds the twenty-four material categories of the classical Sāṃkhya schema, beginning with prakṛti and progressing through the threefold psychic instrument (antahkāraṇa)—intellect (buddhi), ego (ahaṃkāra), and mind (manas)—, the organs of knowledge (buddhīndriya)—the ear (śrotra), the skin (tvak) the eye (cakṣus), the tongue (rasana), and the nose (ghrāṇa)—, the organs of action (karmendriya)—speech (vāk), hands (pāni), feet (pāda), anus (payu), generative organ (upastha)—, the five subtle elements (tanmātra)—sound (śabda), touch (sparśa), color (mahas), taste (rasa) and smell (gandha)—, and, lastly, the physical sphere (sthūla- viṣayas) constituted by the five material elements (pañca-mahābhūtas)—sky (nabhas), wind (pavanas), fire (tejas), water (salila) and earth (pṛthvī) (PS 19- 22).

The result of this process is that consciousness takes the form of a body (dehabhāva) (PS 23). In other words, according to the Trika, the final

result of cosmic manifestation is embodiment. Hence, in this

system, the body is both the product of creation and the receptacle of manifestation itself. Hence, the body contains within itself each of the thirty-six tattvas, and for this reason reflects the structure of the universe.²⁸ Consequently, the tattva schema is to be understood simultaneously as a map of the universe and of the human being--the two, in Tantric circles, being inseparable.²⁹

As we will see below in my translation of Abhinavagupta's *Paramārthasāra*, in the practices of Trika sādhana the homologies between the universe and the body play out on several levels. According to Abhinavagupta's Śaivism, the body itself is not the cause of bondage. It is the final product of Paramaśiva's expansive power (*unmeṣa-śakti*). The true source of bondage is the malas which encase the finite soul (*puruṣa*, *anu*) in ignorance (*avidyā*) and create the experience of cyclical existence or *saṃsāra*. In such a condition, the limited soul, "like a spider with its web, spins for itself a variegated pattern by means of association with the body, breath, perception, thought, knowledge and the expanse of ether" (PS 32). In other words, while governed by the malas, the tattvas are an apparent source of bondage:

When the multitude of tattvas are unagitated the Lord likewise appears still; likewise is He excited when they are so and bewildered when there is the state of bewilderment. However, in actuality, from the [perspective of the] Highest Truth He is not these conditions (PS 38).

The last line of the above verse is the key to understanding the Trika conception of bondage. It suggests, that ultimately, the entire notion of limitation is a cosmic joke, or play (*līla*). In the final analysis, Śiva is never bound,

and in the moment of this re-cognition (*pratyabhijñā*), the sādḥaka is awakened. At that point, the body becomes the temple of god (*devagrha*) and delusion is shattered. Then, there is the condition of embodied liberation (*jīvan- mukta*). Hence, for the Trika śaivite, death is not a prerequisite for final release (*videha- mukta*).³⁰ Knowledge alone is necessary, for in the moment of awakening there is the understanding that Śiva alone unfolds the drama of bondage and release:

He (the sādḥaka) would free his own Self from
bondage by means of the splendor of the greatness

Paradoxically, this moment of re-cognition, this condition of knowing, often requires ritual practices (*karman*) to produce a condition of purification in which pure knowledge can arise. Consequently, the Trika sādhana system enjoins the combining of knowledge and action (*jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda*) as a means to freedom. In defense of this position, the Trika defines the absolute as constituted of a triadic power: will (*icchā*), knowledge (*jñāna*), and action (*kriyā*).

The dimensions of sādhana

Trika theology describes this world as the self- manifestation of an omnipotent and dynamic consciousness. Logically, then, as we have seen, bondage is an impossibility, an illusion or mirage. Yet, there is the experience of suffering and consequently the need for a method (*upāya*) which brings about the dissolving of the mirage of ignorance. Herein, enters the essential features of Tantra—an elaborate technology of self-release based on a science of the body (*dehavidyā*). Within this system, abstract philosophical inquiry as found in the initial sections of the PS, forms part of the means to liberating knowledge (*jñāna*).³¹ In other words, descriptions of the tattvas, the nature of the cosmogonic process, etc., serve not only to satisfy intellectual curiosities, but to finally produce an existential awakening and release. And this condition, the Tantras declare,

requires “active ritual participation leading the aspirant to experiential knowledge (bhāvanajñāna).”³²

Hence, for the initiated sādḥaka, the PS is to be understood not as representing a philosophical stance to be agreed or disagreed with, but as a guideline for acquiring experiential knowledge that was disseminated within guarded circles of initiation and secrecy. Initiation was understood to be the sine qua non of proper textual exegesis, since it was only through this consecration that the malas could be removed. Through dīkṣā came the descent of power (śaktipāṭa) which made possible the revelation of the Self. “As the face is revealed in a spotless mirror,” writes Abhinavagupta, “so This (Self) is revealed as light in the mind purified by śaktipāṭa (PS 9).”

Bondage And Embodiment

The purpose (prayojana) for writing the PS is clearly established by Abhinavagupta in the third verse where he explains that his treatise (śāstra) is written in response to the pleas of a disciple caught in the “wheel of suffering that begins with dwelling in the womb and ends with death.” Living in a universe that is inherently devoid of distinctions, being the self-manifestation of omnipotent consciousness, how then can there be an occasion for bondage? Abhinavagupta answers that this condition paradoxically arises as the result of the absolute’s power of freedom (svātantrya-śakti). In other words, it is precisely because Paramaśiva is unbounded that He/She/It can assume the condition of bondage.

In terms of cosmic emanation, the cause of bondage arises at the level of the sixth tattva (māyā-tattva). At this level, Consciousness is said to assume the capacity of self-limitation (saṅkocana) which makes possible the appearance of

duality and multiplicity. The māyā-tattva is itself composed of five sheaths (kañcukas) which limit the functioning of the five powers (pañca-śakti) of the Pure Order (śuddhādhvan) (PS 16). What results is the formation of the ‘three taints’ (trimala) which encase consciousness and transform it into a limited soul (PS 24).

This initiatory transmission was believed to awaken the aspirant’s own dormant power, the kuṇḍalinī-śakti, which, when awakened arose through the central current (suṣumnā-nāḍi), purifying the latent tendencies (samskāras) and uniting the sādḥaka’s limited identity with that of cosmic identity situated at the crown of the head in the saḥsārā. This path of internal ascension was called the upward yoga (udmukhyayoga) and was considered the distinctive feature of the Kaula school. In mythological terms, the upward path was the upward face of Śiva’s five-faced icon (pañca-mukha-liṅga). This path removed all ignorance and established the sādḥaka in the highest state of empowerment through the shredding of the malas:

As the chaff surrounding the rice grain seems inseparable and yet is removed, so this (=the trimala) is shed by the upward yoga of the path of Śaivism (PS 18).

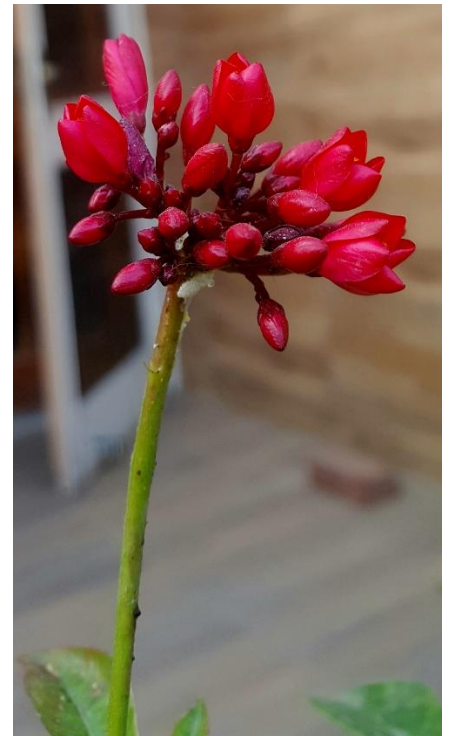
For one to enter the path of upward yoga, the essential prerequisite was the meeting with a qualified master (satguru). Contact with the teacher was understood to produce an alchemical process of transformation that liberated the disciple from all impurities (PS 17). Under rare circumstances, the empowerment received from the guru was so intense (atītivra-śaktipāṭa) it would produce instant enlightenment and the sādḥaka would become “Śiva Himself” (PS 96). More often, however, liberation occurred gradually (karma-mukti) through “ascending the steps of the ladder [of tattvas]” (PS 97).

For a fuller understanding of this process of ascension one can benefit by turning to other texts, both primary

and secondary. Quality work in the field of Kashmir Śaivism is now quite established, thanks particularly to scholars like Alexis Sanderson and his kula in the UK, the many American scholars working in the field (Lawrence, White, Skora, Muller-Ortega) as well as a host of Indian paṇḍitas, including Timalisina, Dyckowski, Mishra and others. In particular, one ought to read the Tantrāloka and Tantrasāra in which Abhinavagupta maps out the path to liberation as a fourfold means (upāyacatuśyayaṃ) in which advanced ritual techniques are understood to correspond to the sādḥaka's own internal state of cognitive development.

Towards this end one can also reflect on the following translation of the Parmārthasāra, in which I have attempted to capture both the literal power and poetic sweetness of Abhinavagupta's reflections on the quintessence (sāra) of the highest (parama) purpose (artha). While this brief text does not provide the detail of other works by Abhinavagupta, it nonetheless distills the essence of his spiritual brilliance. Practiced in its own context, the Parmārthasāra is chanted as litany to a ritualized and meditative visualization practice through which the initiate seeks to re-cognize her own identity as the highest purpose (for the objectivized "goal" is inevitably one's own subjective "self" in Trika-Kaulism). In this state of refined self-as-awareness, purpose (artha), aim (artha) and truth (artha) are all grounded in that Supreme Being who is one's own self-of-self. With this awareness firmly established, the sādḥaka realizes that, indeed, "I alone am the Deity I worship" (śivo'ham)

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Introduction of Vasugupta's Shiva-Sutras



Dr Shashi Tiwari

Kashmir was seat of learning along with Varanasi in ancient northern India. After a great spell of learning at Varanasi insightful people would go to Kashmir for the perfection in philosophy. The doctrine of Recognition where one discovers oneself as one with the Almighty was called *Pratyabhijnana darshan*. Later some orientalisists gave it a popular name 'Kashmir Shaivism'. The most important Agama Shastra of Kashmir-Literature is recognised as the Shiva –Sutras.

Nigama and *Agama* are recognized as great scriptures of ancient India which represent traditions and faith. 'Nigama' is the famous name given to *Apaurusheya* Vedas which are considered to be revelation by Brahman. And so, *Agama Shstras* are those texts which are revealed by Shiva. The Shaiva system of philosophy is generally known as *Shaivagama*.

Shastra is a respected scripture depicting highest truth, expounded by great seers, in reference to a particular system. Systematic documentation of all knowledge related to a particular subject is the definition of the *shastra*. The term '*shastra*' is derived from the root √ *Shas* which means 'discipline.' Hence, *shastra* is that text which describes rules and regulations of discipline and good conduct to be followed by the aspirant and student of that

particular Shastra. In simple words, a Shastra sets down the doctrines and practices for its students or followers.

Kashmir Shaivism occupies a distinguished position among the various schools of religious creed and thought. The universal philosophy focuses on relation between God, Nature and Man. It leads to the highest level of Self-realization, revealing the inner most secrets of the nature of Self. In it all the aspects of life are taken in totality and considered as integrated. The *Kashmir Shaivism* has principles of *Shaivism*, *Agama* and *Tantra Shastra* altogether in a collective form. This philosophy can inspire us for both material and spiritual growth with the goal of uplifting Individual Soul.

The Shiva- sutras are a treatise on Yoga which is based on a definite system of philosophy. The Shiva-Sutras are a collection of seventy seven aphorisms that form the foundation of the tradition of spiritual mysticism known as *Kashmir Shaivism* and are related with its *Advaita* tradition, the Yoga of Supreme Identity. For Kashmir Shaivism, it is one of the most important key sources. It outlines the teachings of Shaiva non-dualism, where the focus is on attaining the Ultimate Reality in which everything is created and dissolved.

The Shiva- sutras are attributed to Acharya Vasugupta of the 9th century C.E. According to general belief these Sutras as an important text were originated from Parama Bhagvan Shiva, and later they were revealed to Vasugupta. His famous descendants were Somananda, Utpaldeva and Abhinavgupa who finally gave a concrete shape and foundation to this philosophy.

Historically these Sutras and the ensuing school of *Kashmir Shaivism* are a *Tantric* or *Agamic* tradition. According to a legend, Vasugupta, the author of the sutras, used to live near Mahadeva Mountain in the valley of Harvan stream near Srinagar. One myth is that he received the aphorisms in a dream visitation of a *Siddha* or semi-divine being. Another is that it came to him in a dream and instructed him to go to a definite

rock on which he would find the teachings Shiva-Sutras inscribed on it. Vasugupta was the *Acarya* (teacher) who expounded Shaiva philosophy for the first time in a systematic and short form. He lived towards the end of the 8th or beginning of the 9th century C.E.

A number of commentaries are written on these Sutras by contemporaries or descendants of Acharya Vasugupta. Most Important of them are Kshemaraja who wrote commentary named '*Vimarshini*' in the 10th Century C.E. Kshemaraja was a student of Abhinavagupta. His commentary is translated by Shri Jaideva Singh and Swami lakshman Joo into English. Another *Acharya* named Bhaskara has prepared his commentary in 11th century C.E. which is called '*Varttika*'.

The first *sūtra* of first section gives the philosophical back ground of this system as well as the experience of *sāmbhava yoga*. It says that *Caitanya* or consciousness is self or nature of reality. *Caitanya* in this system does not mean merely consciousness. It means consciousness which has the absolute freedom of will, knowledge and action. It's essential nature is *cit* (consciousness) and *Ānanda* (bliss). It expresses itself in *icchā* (will), *jñāna* (knowledge) and *kriyā* (action).

The question arises if the essential nature of *jīva* and *jagat*, of all experients and the world is siva, how is it then that all beings in the world do not enjoy the bliss of sīvā, but experience bondage- limitation in respect of willing, knowledge, and action? The answer is that the bondage of the empirical individual is due to *anava*, *mayiya*, and *karma malas* or limiting conditions. *Anava mala* is an innate, limiting. condition which is the primal ignorance of our essential nature as siva. *Mayiya mala* is due to *maya* which gives to the soul its gross and subtle body, and brings about sense of difference and *karma mala* is due to *vāsanās* or impressions left behind on the mind due to *karma* or motivated action.

Without light of consciousness nothing can appear. One of the most sublime passage of Katha Upanishad (2/2/15) says that Atman or consciousness is the light of all lights. 'There (in the Atman) the sun does not illumine, nor the moon and the stars; nor do these lightings illumine there; and much less this fire. When That shines, everything shines, after That. By its light all this manifested universe is lighted'.

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ESSENCE OF NADA - PRIMORDIAL SOUND INTO PRACTICE



Suva

When we are born, we relate to the sound. We relate to the touch, smell, emotions, motions and audio-visual registration. We know that these elements appear as decoding tools that evolved long before the words formed out of the primary core - sound. The words that decorate to form a sentence, more or less can be assumed as a compiled refinement of emotions. Therefore words sit in the secondary mold to cast a spell on the multiplication of diverse differentiation. Gradually humans developed these patterns of lingua franca to highlight the coding system of communication evolving from the sonic space. The distribution of these compact word patterns had been influenced by geographical and cultural palettes, within the umbrella of shifting pigmented civilizations. But in the midst of lingual environment what is the role of sound? How can we discover the essence of primordial sound – *Nada* in our practice and understanding of music? Many scholars have

already interpreted words and notations of sound in myriad textual frames. However to proceed further I will illustrate more on the essence of sound that touched me through my visual, performative and performance practice in the chapters of my artistic growth.

My toddler days were nourished with the sensory filaments of sound through music and the intricacies of rhythm. It was far different than the modern day electrified gadgets that are condensed with screens to touch and type. Sound of Vedic hymns, chants from the Buddhist Gumpa, Sunday morning bells from the nearby church and soothing azan resonating throughout the sky, painted an esoteric environment around the vicinities. Then there was the home atmosphere that magnified story telling sessions, sound of common fireplace, aromatic sound of cooking and the sound of affinity among neighbours. These sounds were the primordial space before words demented my being, by refining and defining the queer world of differences through language, customs, compartmental branding in the name of religion, taboos and cultural razors. What was so appealing about such audible colours?

Being amplified by this sonic space, the creative growth of mine often came up with questions, identifying the body of sound. How would one look into the formalistic feature of sound? Is it possible for us to visually experience the tonal frequency of sound? How can the audible-tonal mood be visually preconceived? These questions may be lyrically answered through an enriching excerpt from the poem – The Brook by Alfred Lord Tennyson :-

“ -----

I chatter over stony ways,
In little sharps and trebles,
I bubble into eddying bays,
I babble on the pebbles.

-----”

(4th stanza)

Tennyson's poem – The Brook, has a phonetic

note towards the depiction of sonic velocity. His verses catch the tonal frequency in lucid typographic scales perceiving a dynamic flow of sound. This poem attempts to record a visual interpretation of audible perambulation that this native stream performs. Would it be appropriate to express that Tennyson explores the primordial sound -*Nada*, while recognizing the suchness of experience?

Nada is the Sanskrit word for “sound,” and meditating on the inner sound means *nada yoga*, also indicates the sound of silence. Coincidentally in Spanish *nada* means “nothing.” It is understood as a primordial sound, being the essence of life and that which resonates in everything. Nada Yoga system dissects the sound of music into two categories: internal music, *anahata*, and external music, *ahata*. The seat of internal music is the heart chakra area (*anahata*), that hosts the beats of life form and receives the subtle sounds, silent to the mundane ear to hear although one can listen to those in depth. We also have one of the valuable philosophical treatises, known as Sama Veda that represents the rapture and devotion to sound in spiritual practice. Sama Veda is the third scriptural understanding along with Rig, Yajur and Atharva; it is described here that “Sapta Swara” or seven notes (Sa Ri Ga Ma Pa Dha Ni similar to Western- Do Re Mi Fa So La Ti) were derived from the sound of non-human humane species in their appropriate season. A table below draws a comparison of the seven notes and it's associations, according to the ancient text of music– Naradiya Shiksha (1.5.3; 1.5.4)

Name in Sama Music	Symbol	Sama Veda Svara	Bird/animal Sound associated
Madhyama	Ma	svarita	heron
Gandhara	Ga	udatta	goat
Rishabha	Ri	anudatta	bull
Shadja	Sa	svarita	peacock
Nishadha	Ni	udatta	elephant

Daiwatha	Dha	anudatta	horse
Panchama	Pa	svarita	Cuckoo

These seven notes are complimenting the external flow of music and also has the possibilities to enter the internal space of sound. There is also “rhythm” that accompanies the rambling notes to keep on the dialogue of sound in its vibration and resonance.

In today's world textual informations on sound of music are in abundance that we can register in our knowledge bank and all the key words are just click away, ready to be captured through the web-net tools. My relation to sound through rhythm and notes pass through transitional phase more aligned to practice and experiencing. The childhood lullabies, rustle of the bamboo trees, smell of the pine tree saps and sound of dew drops, ringing flow of mountain springs and roar of water falls, the morning and evening walks through the green meadows; all these were inspirations to explore beyond the conventional frame. To detect the inner faculty (primordial essence) there is this strong feeling growing in me to excavate the tactile quality of sound. How can I reach through such an element? It is obvious for me to turn my attention towards construction of sculpture incorporating the unconventional matter, mass or channels. Each sculptural creations gradually evolved into deeper understanding of something in between ! That which is the void or the gap, the micro notes between those, the intricacies of rhythmic timing, the kumbak (pausing) stage between Puraka (inhalation) and Rechaka (exhalation) in the rhythm of breathing. These experiences are my notations and potential materials. A medium through which I have been cogitating to process my inner insight so that I can share with others. That is where the avid forms of performance and performing comes alive in my creative venture. There is a thin line between performing and performance (Art), the former that relies on rehearsed formats and the later builds up the format while presenting. This is possible for me

only through improvisation which helps by knowing the space, material and the participatory observers.

Presently we associate demonstrations on sound with a term called Sound Art and Performance. Usual frame of Sound Art has to do with technological devices in most cases dealing with the noise. Bringing the popular in abstract dimension where noise develops an adrenalin state, but then very often we miss out the organic tincture of the primordial essence of sound. We can imitate but cannot produce the subtle purity which can be expressed through acoustic ways. For example, a jolt of thunder with an immense bass sound cannot be the same, even if one imitates this using electronic devices. When I go through the pathways of deeper sound, the acoustic flow touches those high and low frequency tones in a biomorphic semblance and those resembling sensation blends amiably around the space of presentation.

This brings me to the parallel path of Nada yoga which is an art of using sounds and tones to create inner transformations. We know that all living beings relate to the sound of music. Scientists have been discovering the response of the flora and fauna towards sound vibration which pervades all existing matters. In Indian Classical Music we have methods or styles of singing like Dhrupad and Tarana that chromatically evolves through the outer sound and brings us to the vast space of inner sound. We can find such similarities in Throat singing style of Mongolia, that traverses through undertones and overtones. Overtones are also utilized as a tool for sound healing in music therapy, an alternative treatment procedure which is becoming popular presently throughout the world. Then we have the rhythm section very much present in our bodily mechanism, for instance our heart beats. Can we agree to such a concept, that rhythm

evolved from the perambulated timing of our heart complimented by our breathing? In this case we may be aware that our life force is fueled by the application of Nada yogic system. In the practice of Pranayama (breathing technique) one can experience the function of Nada with an effective mudra known as Dhenu Mudra, combination of overtone and Bhrahmari Pranayam. This is performed while sitting in Siddha-asana (posture) and placing the mudra in each chakra points of our body, the base chakra can be represented by placing the mudra on the base of sitting position. For Music practitioners, this pranayama method intensifies to a concentrating mode where one can experience the true essence of Nada – primordial sound world.



Naropa, Kalchakra Tantra and Nalanda tradition



Niraj Kumar

All over the world, the millennial birth anniversary of Naropa is being celebrated this July. As per Drukpa Order, Naropa was born in 1016 A.D. and disappeared into rainbow body in 1100 A.D. without leaving any trace of his physical body. He is also listed as one of the 84 mahasiddha. His teachings of the Six Yogas of Naropa are an essential practice among Himalayan Buddhists.

Naropa was born in a royal family of Bengal. His father was Shantivarman and mother, Srimati. At the age of eleven, he was sent to Kashmir to pursue Buddhist studies under the master Gaganakirti.

Three years after his return from Kashmir, Naropa was married to Vimaladipi, later known as Niguma. But, he wanted to be ordained as a monk. At the age of 28, he left his wife and was fully ordained as the monk. He then stayed in Pullahari for six years and wrote several commentaries on *Guhyasamajatantra*, *Abhidharma-uttaratantra*, *Samvara-udbhava* and *Hevajratantra*. Niguma became one of his disciples and served him while he lived in Pullahari.

Naropa went to nearby Nalanda University in 1049 A.D. and he was elevated to the post of the chancellorship of the famed Nalanda

University. His skill and wisdom spread far and wide and he was known as Mahapandita Abhayakirti.

But, he had a powerful vision of a dakini and he left the position and all his honours to seek his Guru, Tilopa. He received Mahamudra teachings from the Master. He taught in many places. He also established several monasteries in Kashmir and Zaskar. It was at Sani monastery in Zaskar, Ladakh where he is believed to have flown into the sky wearing the Six Bone Ornaments after attaining Enlightenment.

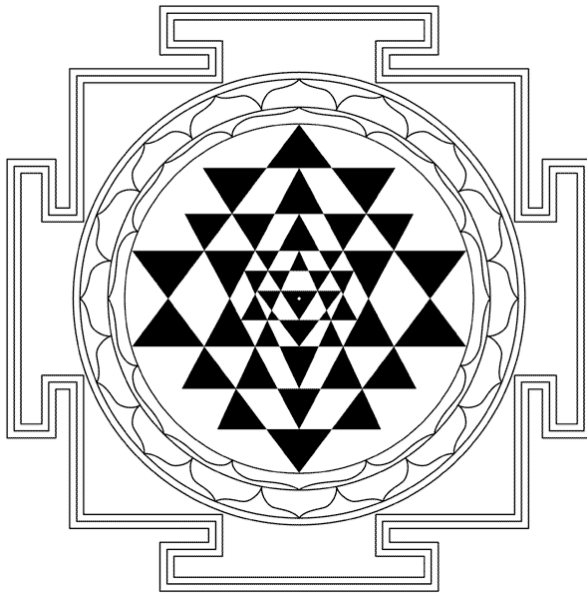
Naropa appears to be a bridge between various vying sects of Buddhist Tantricism and Hindu Tantricism. In fact, he is also known as Nadapada and Nalandapada, attributing his significance in the Nalanda transmission of knowledge. Was Naropa a great synthesizer of Tantrik liturgy like his contemporary, Abhinavagupta? Can we link up dots in various narratives by rereading Naropa?

In my earlier book, **Sriyantra and Geophilosophy of India**(2014), I have hinted at the common origin of both Sriyantra and the Kalacakra Tantra system. At many places in Srividya texts, it is termed as the system of Kalacakra and one often finds mention of Kalacakra yantras. On the other hand, the Kalacakra Tantra is often glorified as the Tantra of Sri in the text itself. The similarities in the conception of both the system is quite astounding. Both tantras have similar conception about the Nriya Devis, the movement of the sun and the moon, the division of time. Interestingly, in both Tantras, we discover mention of similar seed syllables of हसक्षमलवरय. What Sriyantra is with a triangular structure, the Kalacakra mandala is a manifestation of a quadrilateral structure. The triangle is the shape of the fire element and the square, the shape of the earth element. Thus, two systems are merely methods to accomplish control of different elements in similar way. If one gloss over the history of the

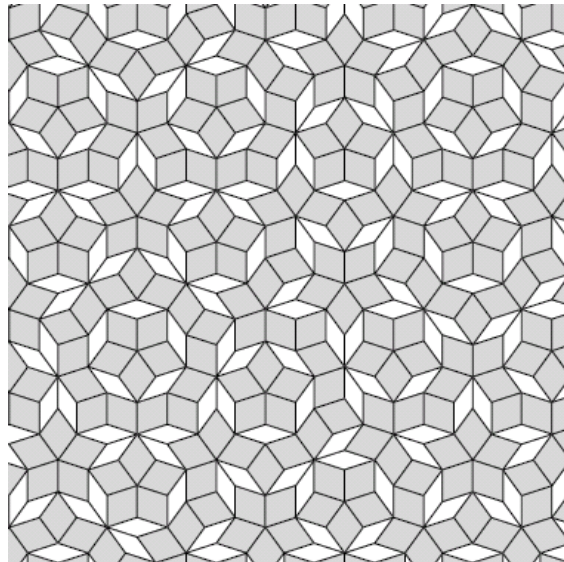
Kalacakra Tantra, one often finds mention that the King Suchandra received the Kalacakra Tantra at Dhanyakataka in Andhra Pradesh which lies adjacent to the famous Amravati stupa and the Sripavata. Sripavata was also a centre of Srividya and the Deccan was stronghold of the Srividya at the time of emergence of Kalacakra Tantra and in all likelihood provided the template for the higher level synthesis of four-sided structure in place of three-sided structure. By understanding the Shadanga Yoga of Naropa with fresh perspective, we can decipher the transformation of the Sriyantra structure into the Kalacakra structure. Interestingly, it took another millennium for mankind to generate another higher layer(five-sided structure) integration through Penrose's pentagonal tilings.



(Kalacakra- Four-sided Integration)



(Sriyantra-Three –sided Integration)



(Penrose's pentagonal tilings- Five-sided Integration)

Authorship of Kalacakra Tantra

There has been lot of debates about the actual authorship of Kalacakra Tantra. While most of the scholars agree that it was brought by Kalacakrapada, the Senior; Naropa, the great Yogi and one of the Mahasiddhas whose

lineage flourish under the Drukpas, was the first to receive the Kalacakra Tantra in India. Drukpas are celebrating 1000th year of Naropa's birth this year. Naropa (1016-1100AD) is said to be the main master who transmitted the Kalacakra Tantra through two lineages into Tibet- Ra lineage through Pandit Somanath and Dro lineage through Samantashri.

Lokesh Chandra after extensive study of Tibetan catalogues writes that the Kalacakra was introduced into India from Shambhala sixty years before its arrival in Tibet. The records suggest that it entered Tibet in the year 1026 A.D. According to the Tibetan historian Padma Karpo, Tsilupa is the Great Kalacakrapada and Naropa(Skt. Nadapada) is the Lesser Kalacakrapada. Padma Karpo also writes that Naropa was initiated by Tsilupa into Kalacakra tradition at the Pullahari monastery, near Biharsharif in Bihar where Naropa later met Marpa(1012-1097 AD) and prophecy about Milarepa(1052-1097 A.D.) was made. Naropa also initiated Atisha(982 A.D. - 1054A.D.) into Kalacakra tradition.

There is a serious chronological discrepancy here. Naropa was initiated by the mahasiddha Tilopa(928-1009 A.D.). Naropa served his Master for 12 years before he could realize the mahamudra. Before meeting Tilopa, Naropa was already heading the Nalanda Mahavihara after his extensive study in Kashmir and other centers of learning. Naropa was ordained as a monk after eight years into his marriage at the age of 28 before he joined Nalanda. This puts Naropa's life at around 960 A.D. Many scholars now put for Naropa's birth in 956 A.D. and his period from 956-1040 A.D. This removes the discrepancy in different narratives as a senior Naropa could have become so famous that Marpa, the Translator from Tibet visited him and he could also initiate disciples like famous Atisha and Pandit Somanatha. It

is improbable to establish Naropa's birth in 1016 A.D. because then he , in no way, could have been initiated by Tilopa who passed away in 1009 A.D. and could have initiated Somanatha in Kalacakra Tantra and sent him to Tibet to establish Kalacakra Tantra there in 1026 A.D.

In the Kalacakra Tantra(KCT) treatise itself, there is mention of lapse of 403 years from the beginning of the calendar. Many scholars try to establish the chronology of introduction into Tibet in 1026 A.D. by bringing into calculation Islamic calendar which commenced in 623A.D. The KCT text mentions the year of introduction in number symbol (I.27 in Lokdhatupatal) and clearly mentioning about the calculations in the Mlechhavarsa ; as when there were three fires, space was empty like zero and there were four oceans- pointing to 403 years. Vimalprabha further explains that this year is the year of mlecchas which points to the Islamic calendar.

Since different genealogies also point to the introduction of KCT in Tibet in 1027 A.D., the beginning of the Tibetan calendar; the year of introduction has no conflicting interpretation. But, if Naropa was the first Indian student and the tantra was introduced 60 years before its introduction in Tibet, the origin of Tantras in 967 A.D. can safely be assumed. Tilopa would have been 40 years old and in all likelihood, Tilopa himself was the Kalacakrapada , the Elder. This will also clear the confusion around the Cilupa, a name that appears to be derivative of Tilopa.

In fact, there are so many similarities between the Sadanga Yoga which Tilopa taught to Naropa and the Yoga of the Kalacakra that it can be clearly stated that without an understanding of the Sadang Yoga of Tilopa-Naropa, the Kalacakra Tantra could not have been composed. If the ultimate accomplishment of Mahamudra as the union of the illusory body(Shunyata- Bimba) and the clear light(Vimal- Prabha or Prabhasvara-citta) is the leitmotif of

the Kalacakra tantra, the two terminologies and concepts are derivatives of Tilopa-Naropa's Sadanga Yoga only. The fixation of constituting Reality into 36 elements, comprising six sets of six elements each itself appears to be the further elaboration of the Sadanga Yoga of Tilopa-Naropa. While Hindu tradition of Yoga focus on the Ashtanga Yoga(eight-folded) and the KCT also aims to fuse both Hindu and Buddhist system, the emphasis on Sadang rather than Ashtang yoga also points to Tilopa-Naropa as the progenitor of the Kalacakra tantra. The Evam(एवं) as the summation of the Kalacakra Tantra itself means fusion(Evam in Sanskrit means "and"). It symbolizes the total integration of sunyata and karuna(emptiness and compassion). This evam beejamantra has been enunciated in the Tilopa-Naropa's Sadanga Yoga where the crown cakra contains the syllable ए (Ae), the throat cakra, वं(Vam), the heart cakra- वं(Vam) and the navel cakra, ए (ae). Thus, forming the aroha-avaroha(आरोह अवरोह or the to and fro movement) of the Evam-Vamaeh(एवं वंए), a sort of cyclic repetition of the generation-dissolution-utapatti-nishpatti- as we find in the then Hindyu Tantras like Aham-Maha(अहं महा) or the Vedantic mantra of सोऽहं हंस!

Tilopa-Naropa's Sadanga yoga and Origin of Kalacakra Tantra

Tilopa received four transmissions. The instructions on Mahamudra(Great seal) came through Saraha → Luipa → Darkapa and Dingipa → Tilopa. Second instructions on the Father Tantras(that included the entering the body and practice of transference was transmitted from the line of Ratnamati → Nagarjunagarbha → Matangi → Tilopa. Third instruction on Inner

Heat(Tumo/Candali/Kundalini), intermediate state(bardo) and Karmamudra all based upon Mother tantras was transmitted through line of female dakini, Sumati Samantabhadri → Vajraghantapada → Tilopa. Fourth instruction on radiant light, lucid dreaming and the illusory body(Maya Kaya) was transmitted through the line of Dombipa → Vinas → Kambalipa → Indrabhuti → Tilopa. Thus, the Tilopa-Naropa tradition fused the opposite streams of Father tantras(Guhyasamaja tantra)and the female tantras(Hevajra and Cakrasamvara Tantras).

Glenn Mullin in his Six Yogas of Naropa gives somehow different lines of transmission as mentioned by Tsongkhapa- inner heat yoga came from the Mother tantras- Hevajra and Cakrasamvara through Krishnacarya. Illusory Body yogas and the clear light yoga came from Jnanagarbha while the practice of transference of consciousness and projections came through the Chaturpita tantra. In fact, Tilopa summarized his six-Yoga synthesis under the Sanskrit title, Satadharma Upadeshnama(षट्धर्म उपदेश नामा). In this text written by Naropa from the words of Tilopa and translated by Marpa at Pullahari, Tilopa is believed to have mentioned that he received instructions of Mahamudra from Shavari, inner heat yoga from Krishnacharya; clear light and bardo yoga from Mahasiddha Lawpa, and the Guhyasamaj transmission from Nagarjuna.

The fusion of Father and Mother Tantra once accomplished, they enunciated an elaborate Sadang Yoga which is summarized below:

- i) Tummo (Tb: gtum-mo, Sanskrit: caṇḍālī चाण्डाली) — the yoga of inner heat (or mystic heat).
- ii) Gyulü (Tb: sgyu-lus, Sk: māyākāyā मायाकाया) — the yoga of the illusory body.
- iii) Ösel (Tb: hod-gsal, Sk: prabhāsvaraप्रभास्वर) — the yoga of the clear light or radiant light.

- iv) Milam (Tb: rmi-lam, Sk: svapnadārśana स्वप्नदर्शन) — the yoga of the dream state.
- v) Bardo (Tb: bar-do, Sk: antarābhava अन्तरभाव) — the yoga of the intermediate state. This is well-known through the Bardo Thödöl. Bardo yoga is fusion of techniques of illusory body yoga and dream yoga.
- vi) Phowa (Tb: hpho-ba, Sk: saṃkrānti संक्रान्ति) — the yoga of the transference of consciousness to a pure Buddhafield.

The **yugnaddha**(yab-Yum) position is illustrative of the fusion of these two streams of father and Mother Tantras, but has been misinterpreted recently as sexual yoga.

The synthesis of Father and Mother Tantras having been achieved, it appears that Tilopa-Naropa started to work upon a comprehensive fusion of Hindu and Buddhist Tantras. Since Srividya had achieved fusion of various methods to some extent among various Hindu sects after Sankaracharya popularized the same from Kashmir to Kanchi and Puri to Dwarka; the two mahasiddhas opted for four-sided integration for higher order synthesis.

They transformed the Kaya doctrine of Buddhism(Trikayaत्रिकाया). The fourth, Svabhavikakaya (स्वाभाविक काया) or the Sahajkaya(सहज काया) constituted by the Vajradhatu(वज्रधातु), was introduced. Apart from the body (kaya), vak(speech), and chitta(mind); doctrine of vajrakaya was introduced. There were to be four cakra in the Six Yoga system each corresponding to a particular Kaya. Thus, the mahasukha cakra (crown white), sambhogchakra(throat, red), Dharmachakra(heart, blue) and Nirmanchakra(navel, yellow); each corresponded to the four kayas. Four geometrical features- bindu(dot), triangle, circle and square was integrated. Concept of

four mudras- Karma, dharma, samay, mahamudra- was introduced. Concept of four bliss (ananda)- kamananda, parmananda, virmananda and sahananda- was introduced. The birth was classified as of four kinds- from womb, from egg, from fusion of heat and moisture and miraculous. Buddhist philosophy was classified into four - Vaibhashika(analyst- all things, inner and outer, are real), Sautantrika(traditionalist), Chittamatra(idealist, only mind is real) and Madhyamaka(centrist, neither external object nor mind are real, all are empty of essence). Even the moment(kshana-क्षण) was divided into four- vichitra(विचित्र- variety), vipak(विपक्व- fruition), vimard(विमर्द्- consummation) and vilakshana(विलक्षण- lacking characteristics). Memory was classified with four stages(Chatursmriti Upasthana). Tantras were classified into four subsequently- Kriya, Charya, Yoga and Anuttarayoga.

Nine enclosures of the Sricakra were now appropriated under the concept of nine blending. These nine blending each corresponded to the nine bardos(a station amidst a continuous flow). The bardo was merely the rediscovery of the concept of bhumi among the Mahayanists.

Three Blendings of Sadanga Yoga

Kayas

Bardos



The Kalacakra or the Great Wheel of Time as a deity was created to achieve this fusion, since time is an invariable concept among all the sects. Similarly, the whole process of realization was

based upon analogies from the space-which are again invariant in different belief system. Kalacakra was imagined as the ultimate bliss(Mahasukha) . The deity is the unity of prajna and upaya, sun and the moon, earth and the sky, white male bindu and the red female bindu, subjective and objective, lalna and rasna, Hindu Tantras and Buddhist Tantras. The detailed representation of deities and their symbols were discarded in the ultimate stage of Kalacakra Tantra. The body of empty forms (Shunyaata-bimba शून्यात बिम्ब) was conceptualized. Such visualization was sect-invariant. This stage is different from practicing the yoga of illusory body (माया काया). The KCT did away with manipulation of nadis(channels) and vayus(winds). All ought to be dissolved to attain the state of the clear radiant mind (प्रभास्वरचित्त). A clear radiant mind always generate empty forms(शून्यात बिम्ब) just as the in divination mirrors, figures appear on their own. Thus, the empty-forms are like the pratimurti(प्रतिमूर्ति). The natural emergence of these empty-forms has been termed as Svaras (स्वरस). The Masters thence tried to fuse aesthetic theory with the spiritual experience just as Abhinavagupta achieved with his innovative conceptualization of camatkar (चमत्कार) , Masters deployed the concept of Bimba-nishpatti(बिम्ब निष्पत्तिः) or the savouring of the empty-forms just like in aesthetics there is rasanishpattih (रस निष्पत्तिः). The concept of nishpattih also is a double entendre. It is the opposite of utapattih(उत्पत्तिः) i.e. generation state. Nishpattih is thence the dissolution or the consummation state. The bimba-nishpattih is also the svaras(स्वरस). Thus, the ultimate dissolution of even empty-forms is the state of joy, the mahasukha (महासुख). The sahaikaya is attained with shunyatabimbakaya on body side and the mahasukhkaya on mind side. This state of buddhsahood is without wind(avat अवात) and Nirvana is attained which is without support(अप्रतिष्ठित निर्वाण). The Masters further

postulated that it is the state of a clear radiant mind(प्रभास्वरचित्त) to generate the empty-forms just like the sunrays emerge from the sun.

To cultivate joy(ananda आनंद) by cultivating spontaneous empty forms(sahaj Shunyaat Bimb) beyond all prapancha(प्रपञ्चा) i.e. mental fabrications is the ultimate way to attain the sect-invariant realization . The whole yogic process in Naropa's Sadang yoga starts from meditating over an empty shell within one's body(a hollow lotus stalk or Nal ,नाल). Nalanda (नालंदा) appears to be the spatialization of this realization and Nalanda tradition which Naropa(Nalandapa) spread far and wide by synthesizing multiple liturgical heritage , continues to thrive across the Himalayas.

When the synthesis of different streams of belief system has become necessary in the contemporary world, the world needs to seek inspiration from the works of Naropa. The possibility of attunement of the inner world with outer world does provide hope that some day mankind can obliterate violence, greed and envy from the face of the earth and can derive joy from harnessing the Shunya-bimba. This will be the final blow to the predatory capitalism which thrives now on multiplying desires based upon sign-economy . In the world bombarded by the sign-economy, the counter-resistance will require harnessing the power of empty-signs, the Sunyatara! Naropa's vision holds the ultimate key!

(Niraj Kumar is a student of Nalanda Tradition. He received initiation from swami ranganathanadaji Maharaj of Ramakrishna Order.)

Sun Temple at Modhera (Gujarat)



Dr. Advaitavadini Kaul

SUN-worship in Gujarat is known from remote antiquity as in whole of India. In Gujarat prevalence of the sun-cult is indicated by the number of inscriptions found. This is further strengthened by the distribution of monumental remains as also the discovery of a number of stone sculptures of the pantheon from various parts of Gujarat dating from about 5th century B.C. to late mediaeval period.

The temple at Modhera is the most important of all sun-temples built in the whole of Gujarat. It enjoys the same significance as other two well known sun-temples in Kashmir (Martand) and Orissa (Konark). The remains of this magnificent architectural monument still reflect the glimpses of elegance and testify the sanctity of the site.

Modhera or Modherapura also known as Mundera is said to have been the original settlement of modha Brahmans. Having its legendary past relating to the Ramayana it is further believed that modha Brahmans received Modhera as a *krsnarpana* on the occasion of the marriage of Rama and Sita. According to the *Skanda Purana* (3.2.40-67) after defeating Ravana,

Lord Rama consulted Muni Vasishta to show him a place of pilgrimage where he could go and purify himself of the sin of Brahma hatya (the slaying of a Brahman). The Muni showed him dharmaranya.

In *dharmaranya*. Lord Rama settled at a village called Modherak and performed a *yajna* there. Thereafter he established a village and named it Sitapura. It is believed that the village Modherah mentioned above, later came to be known as Modhera. The Sitapura village is about 8 km from Becharagi. Once a flourishing town and seaport, Modhera stands 24 km south of Anahitapataka (Patan) on the left bank of Pushpavati river. And the famous sun temple was constructed to the west of this river probably in 1026-27 A.D. during the reign of Chalukya King Bhima I (1022-1063 A.D.)

As has happened with the rest of the temples in India this temple also suffered from the fundamentalist ravages. "The Muhammadans not content with defacing the figure sculptures of this Modhera temple, are said to have placed bags of gunpowder in the underground shrine and blew it with the upper cell destroying *sikhara* or tower." A monument of incomparable beauty, this temple has been constructed in accordance with the *shilpasashtra*. The appearance of the whole scheme with its architectural setting including its accessories, show that as in all good buildings, the needs and the conveniences of the undertaking are counted equally essential as its aesthetic treatment.

The whole structure standing on a *kharasila* (basement) consisted of the *garbhagrha* (shrines) and *guha-mandapa* (a hall), a *Sabha-mandapa* or *ranga-mandapa* (assembly hall or outer hall/theatre hall), locally known as Sita Chavadi. In front of the temple is the *kunda* (sacred pond) now called the Ramakunda. Originally, there were some

small subsidiary shrines, which have been destroyed.

The general structure of main body of the temple enclosing the *mandapa* (hall) and *garbhagrha* (sanctum sanctorum) is rectangular, with its length inside the walls 51 feet 9 inches which is almost exactly double of its width of 25 feet and 8 inches. Thus the total area of about 1275 sq.ft is divided into nearly two equal halves. The inner half occupies the *garbhagrha* and the front one the *mandapa* (hall). The *sanctum sanctorum* is 11 feet square inside. Between the outer walls of the *sanctum sanctorum* and that of the temple is the *pradakshinamarga* or *bhrama* (the circumambulatory passage). This passage was roofed with flat slabs laid across and carved with rosettes on the undersides and above this, rose the *sikhara*.

The *mandapa* as usual is peristylar with an octagonal nave covered by a splendidly carved dome. The inside walls are bare but broken by niches in each bay, containing figure of Surya. The plain walls are more than compensated by the exquisitely carved pillars and the architraves portraying scenes from the Ramayana. The exterior of the temple is also profusely sculptured but perhaps the most elegant and ornamental feature of this temple is the beautiful *sabha mandapa* (the assembly hall). It is carved with scenes from the Mahabharata. On its outside walls are some representations of amorous couples similar to that at Konark.

Outside this *sabha-mandapa* are two pillars of a *torana* from which the arch is missing. From the *torana* a flight of steps leads down to the kunda in front of it. The Surya-kunda also known as Rama-kunda is rectangular and measures 176 feet north to south, by 120 feet east to west. It has many terraces and steps leading to the water level. On its sides and corners are various small shrines with the

images of gods and goddesses namely Jalasayi Vishnu, Trivikrama, Goddess Shitala etc. "In viewing the Modhera temple as a whole the aesthetic sense at once responds to the elegance of its proportions, the entire composition being lit with the living flame of inspiration. But apart from its material beauty, its designer has succeeded in communicating to it an atmosphere of spiritual grace. The temple faces the east so that the rising sun at the equinoxes filters in a golden cadence through its openings, from door way to corridor, past columned vestibules finally to fall on the image in its innermost chamber.

In its passage the rays of the heavenly body to which the shrine is consecrated, quiver and shimmer on pillars and archway giving life and movement to their graven form, the whole structure appearing radiant and clothed in glory. To see this noble movement with its clustered columns not only rising like exhalation but mirrored in the still waters below, is to feel that its creator was more than a great artist, but weaver of dreams."

There exists famous temple of Matangi Madeshwari Mata, the original temple being in the ancient step-well. Various Modha communities worship the *Mata* as the family deity. Around the temple a large dharmashala has been constructed to accommodate pilgrims on *Mahasud* 13, when a big fair is held. It is attended by the pilgrims from Patan, Ahmedabad, Nadiad etc. On the *chaitrapurnima* day the *sangha* of the Modha ghanchis come here for worship. Fairs are also held on the *sravana vad* 30 and the *adhika mas* vad 30. A special fair is also held on the *Mahotta parva* i.e. conjunction of Monday, Vad 30 and a particular planet. Thousands of people from India and abroad visit the place every month.

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KASHMIR'S CONTRIBUTION TO INDIAN AESTHETICS



Dr. S.S Toshkhani

To understand the full significance of the art-ideas introduced by the successive Kashmiri thinkers, we shall have to look at them in the overall perspective of the development of Indian aesthetical thought. As we know, it is in the Natya Shastra, the legendary Bharata's monumental treatise on dramaturgy, that we find the first systematic exposition of Rasa-a concept central to Indian aesthetic thinking. Supposed to have been written between the 2nd century BC and the 2nd century AD, the Natya Shastra provides a deep insight into the psychology of aesthetic experience. It conceives of the drama as the perfect synthesis between all arts and integrates in its form poetic text, histrionics, stage-craft, music, dance, painting and even architecture into an organismic whole, with Rasa as its soul. "There is no art", claims Bharata, "no science, no craft, no skill that does not fall within the purview of drama".

Na Tajjnana no tat shilpam N sa vidya na sa kala

Na sau yogo na tat karma Natye'smin yanna-drishyate

His well known formulation on Rasa in the Natya Shastra-vibhavanubhava vyabhichari bhava samyogad rasanish-pattih-explains the aesthetic experience in terms of the prime stimuli or the leading characters in a dramatic presentation, their behavioural features and the transient but ancillary emotional reactions they evoke. Scholars have variously interpreted and translated the Sanskrit terms vibhava, anubhava, sanchari bhava and rasa according to their individual perceptions of what these terms mean. Thus, Dr K.C. Pandey translates vibhava as the emotive situation, anubhava as the physical changes consequent upon the rise of an emotion, vyabhichari bhava as transient emotions and rasa as the aesthetic object. Raniero Gnoli prefers to use expressions like "Determinants", "Consequents" and "Transitory Mental States" for them, leaving rasa untranslated. For the purpose of this paper, however, I have mostly used the equivalents given by Krishna Chaitanya for these key terms for the essential constituents of the aesthetic presentation which enables the aesthetic emotion to be experienced and relished.

We shall have to examine a few more concepts before Bharata's formulation becomes a bit more clear. The vibhavas or the primary stimuli arouse the conative dispositional factors abiding in human nature, which cannot be exactly called instincts but could be described as innate sentiments. In Sanskrit poetics these abiding mental states have been given the name sthayi bhavas. It is the sthayi bhava or basic sentiment awakened by the union of vibhavas, anubhavas and the vyabhichari bhavas that is finally relished as rasa. Put in simpler terms this means that when the prime stimuli or determinants, their consequent behavioural pattern and the transient but ancillary emotional

reactions they evoke combine, the basic sentiment is activated and develops into rasa or aesthetic emotion and Wonder (vismaya)

To these a ninth one, Serenity (shama) was added later. The corresponding nine rasas are:

the Erotic (shringara), the Comic (hasya), the Pathetic (karuna), the Furious (raudra), the Heroic (vira),

the Terrible (bhayanaka),

the Odious (bibhatsa),

and the Marvellous (adbhuta).

With this background we can now proceed to understand how ideas which eventually crystallised to form a cogent theory of rasa took off from this point of departure. Going back to Bharata's formulation, the Rasa Sutra, we find that it contained two crucial words that lent themselves to various interpretations, unleashing storms of controversy. These were samyoga and nishpattih. There were other questions also that arose from Bharata's condensed but pregnant statement. Where is Rasa located? Is the aesthetic experience subjective or objective? How is it related to the other emotions or states of consciousness? Every participant in the great debate that ensued took a stand on these on the basis of his

own philosophical outlook. Among the earliest to address these questions was Bhatta Lollata who lived in Kashmir in the late 8th century or the early 9th. A contemporary of the great Shaivite thinker Bhatta Kallata, Lollata approached those questions as a Mimamsaka or grammarian. His works have unfortunately been lost, but from what we learn from the Abhinava Bharati, Abhinavagupta's commentary on the Natya Shastra, Lollata took only the denotational

sense of the word nishpattih into consideration and interpreted it as causal origination. Rasa, he said, is an effect of which the vibhavas or the aesthetic object is the direct cause. It resides in the original historical character (Rama etc.) represented on the stage, as well as the impersonating actor. The actor feels himself as the represented historical personage during the duration of the enactment but remembers his real nature through the faculty of anusandhana or recollection (realization, according to Gnoli).

It is really very exciting to think that this small paradisaical Valley nestled in the Himalays has produced a succession of brilliant thinkers who have formulated most of the fundamental concepts of Sanskrit poetics and have given us a whole body of aesthetic thought profound in conception and impressive in volume and value. One cannot but be overwhelmed by the fact that almost all the major schools of Indian aesthetics were founded by Kashmiri theoreticians - the Alankara School by Bhamaha, Riti School by Vamana, Vakrokti School by Kuntaka, Dhvani School by Anandavardhana and Auchitya School by Kshemendra. Though the concept of Rasa was evolved by Bharata, and perhaps by thinkers even before him, it was only the great Abhinavagupta who perfected it as an integrating theory basic to the aesthetic philosophy of the Indians. Nor was the contribution of those Kashmiri rhetoricians any less important who analysed, interpreted, elaborated and commented upon what the original exponents propounded, thus providing the building blocks on which the Indian aesthetic thought stands today. Profound thinkers like Udbhata, Bhatta Lollata, Shankuka, Bhatta Nayaka, Bhatta Tauta, Rudrata, Ruyyaka, Mahima Bhatta and others. The issues they raised, the solutions they provided, the views they propounded provided grist to the great intellectual debates about the relation of aesthetic object and aesthetic

experience which raged throughout India for quite a long time.

The important question underlying all this discussion is as to how the poetic emotion is transferred from life to art, and Lollata's answer is that the spectator relishes *rasa* or the sentiment located in the character portrayed directly and not through emotional induction by the aesthetic process of activating it. Abhinavagupta quickly rejects this view-point which seeks to turn the sentiment or *sthayi bhava* into an object of perception. Pointing this out, Krishna Chaitanya writes: "Abhinava Gupta's brilliant mind noticed at once that the literalism of the Mimamsakas would annex aesthetics to grammar and bring about as complete an impoverishment in aesthetics as it had brought in philosophy. He saw that Lollata was confusing aesthetic communication with intellectual discourse, the emotive symbol with the denotative sign. Noting that the *sthayi bhava*, which abides as a potential reality and is raised to the relishable state only through the configuration of stimuli etc. (*vibhavadi*), Abhinava argues that it cannot be staticised as an object of perception "existing at only one specific conjunction of space and time." Mammata, an eleventh century Kashmiri aesthete, endorses Abhinava's views by stressing that the object in art is a virtual and not a physical object. It is a virtual object "because the whole phenomenon is processual, the process involving the activity of institution and emotion". Bhatta Lollata's theory, it seems, is totally unconcerned with the spectator's view-point. Shankuka, another Kashmiri and a younger contemporary of Lollata, approaches the problem of how the spectator relishes *rasa* or the aesthetic experience from the point of view of a logician, *naiyayaka*, which he actually was. *Rasa*, he said, applying syllogistic reasoning, was not produced as an effect as Lollata claimed but could be logically arrived at by the process of inference. Using the analogy of a forest fire he

says that just as it can be inferred from the smoke rising from above the top of a cluster of trees, in the same manner the basic mental state can be inferred from the situation presented by the stimuli etc.

Dr K.C. Pandey calls Shankuka's point of view "psycho-epistemic". "In actual life", he points out explaining Shankuka's view-point, "the mental state of a man is revealed by the visible effects of his feeling i.e. the consequents and their concomitant feelings or the transitory mental state. The successful imitation by the actor of the characters and their experiences is no doubt, Shankuka says, artificial and unreal or illusory but is not realised to be so by the spectators who forget the difference between the actors and the characters and inferentially experience the mental state of the characters themselves". Shankuka, in fact, uses the analogy of a painted horse, *chitraturaga*, to bring out the beauty of this imitation (*anukarna*) and holds that aesthetic experience, which is a peculiar form of inference (*anumana*), cannot be classified under any known forms of knowledge.

Shankuka's views, like those of Lollata, have been presented in brief by Abhinavagupta in his famous commentary on *Natya Shastra*, the *Abhinava Bharati*, as Shankuka's works too are lost. The inference and imitation theories of Lollata and Shankuka, which hold the aesthetic presentation to be "the efficient cause (*karaka hetu*) or the logical cause (*jnapak hetu*)" respectively of the aesthetic emotion, were later demolished by Abhinava and the exponents of the *Dhvani* or Suggestion School of poetics. But before we look at what they have to say in the matter, let us try to appreciate the views of Bhatta Nayaka, a great aesthetic thinker who lived in the late 9th century Kashmir and joined the debate to point out the "inwardness of the whole situation". Here again we have to rely upon the *Abhinava Bharati* as Bhatta Nayaka's work the *Hridaya Darpana*, too

is not available. He rejects the idea that rasa or the aesthetic emotion can be affected or inferred, and tries to extend the Sankhya concept of bhoga or enjoyment to the field of aesthetics. Rasa, he posits, is neither atmagata nor paragata nor is it tatastha vedyā. That is, it cannot be perceived as located in the spectator or as located in anyone else, whether it be the character portrayed or the actor portraying that character. We can have no perception of rasa at all: “rasah na pratiyate”!.

What Bhatta Nayaka means in other words is that the spectator or the reader does not feel the sorrow or the happiness of the character represented personally as his own because of the aesthetic distance. That is why even a tragic play or a poem does not cause any feeling of pain in him and he is able to “enjoy” or savour its flavour too. Further, he says, ordinary spectator or reader can never identify himself with the extraordinary virtues of such a great hero as Rama. What happens actually is that he enjoys the aesthetic emotion through the bhojaka-bhojya relationship. That is, through the relationship of the enjoyer and the enjoyed. Bhatta Nayaka, thus, stresses the importance of bhavana vyapara or imagination, which, according to him, comes into play as an aspect of aesthetic experience. Poetic experience, he maintains, has another power besides abhidha or the denotational power which enables the sahrīdaya or the aesthetically sensible person to see the characters presented in an aesthetic creation in a generalised way, “independently of any relationship with his ordinary life or the life of the actor or the hero of the play or poem”, as Gnoli puts it. This special power Bhatta Nayaka calls bhavakatva, the power of generalisation.

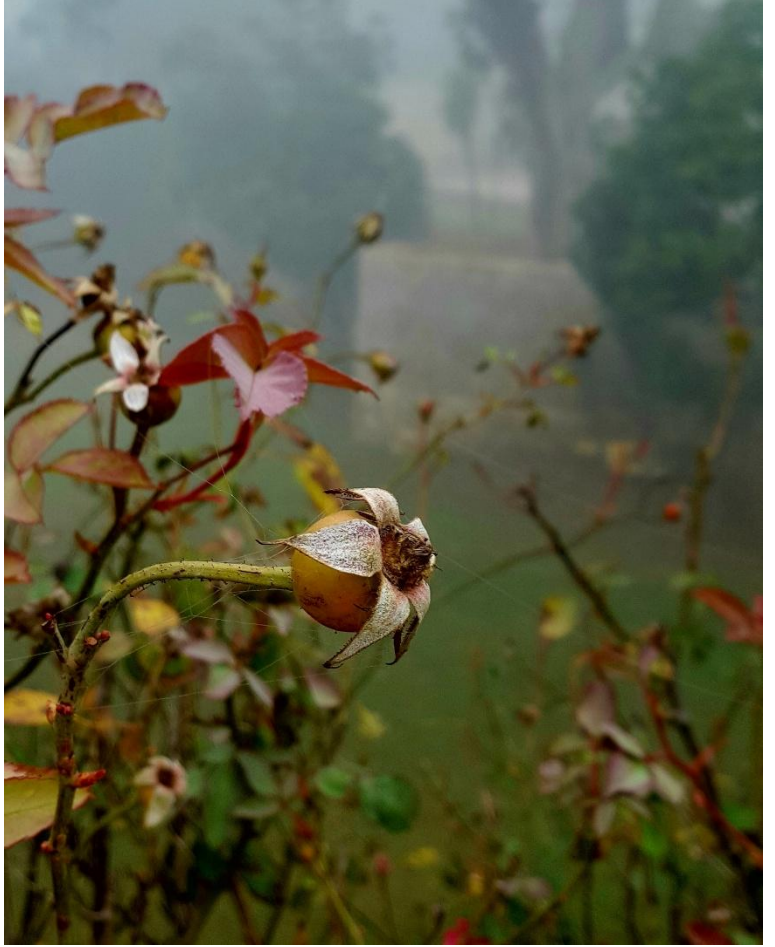
To explain the relation between the subject and object, Bhatta Nayaka posits another power or function of language - that of bhojakatva or enjoyment. It is by the virtue of this power, according to him, that we relish the experience presented in a poetic creation, not at the practical but at the aesthetic level. All practical considerations fade away due to the predominance of sattva or innate goodness of human nature, a state of psychological poise which makes us repose in our own consciousness. The other two potentialities described in the Sankhya philosophy, rajas, physical dynamism and tamas, insensibility, are rendered ineffective. Thus the bhoga or enjoyment of rasa is a process of delectation very much akin to the state of self-sufficient blissful consciousness which one experiences on realising the Supreme Reality (Brahman). Bhatta Nayaka's another important contribution, therefore, is that he brings the aesthetic experience at par with mystic experience. By stressing that it is not determined by practical considerations but is a state of being, he makes it more internal and contemplative, bringing the relisher face to face with the ultimate Universal Reality

In his comment on Bhatta Nayaka's formulation about universalisation of experience in aesthetics, Abhinavagupta does not seem inclined to dismiss it altogether. In fact, he absorbs his core contentions into his own aesthetic theory and develops them in accordance with his own monistic outlook. He admits that aesthetic enjoyment is similar to the joy that comes from realising one's identity with Brahman, but he rejects his three-fold classification of the powers of language on the ground that there is no need “to staticise either the generalising function of poetry as a separate power of bhavakatva or the appreciative activity of the reader or spectator as a distinct, isolated power bhojakatva”, as this only leads to unnecessary multiplication of concepts.

We shall refer to Abhinavgupta's philosophy of aesthetics later. Suffice it to say here that he accepted Bhatta Nayaka's view that the aesthetic and the mystic experiences spring from the same source and the bliss we derive from them is a state of independence from all extraneous factors--a repose into our own self. But while the state of mystical consciousness is marked by "the complete disappearance of all polarities, the lysis of all dialectics in the dissolving fire of God", to use the words of R.Gnoli "in aesthetic consciousness the feelings and facts of everyday life remain always present", even though they are transfigured. The fact put so succinctly by K.Krishnamurthy, is that so far as the idea of rasa is concerned, Abhinavgupta "takes over where Bhatta Nayaka leaves".

(To be concluded)

(Dr. S.S Toshkhani is a poet, linguist, writer and a thinker. He has contributed substantially to Kashmiri heritage and carried out modern research in various fields of Kashmiri literature, history, religion, art and social sciences.)



An analysis of the eternity of the elements of semantic relationship in the context of the Trikagama text of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta

Shivananda Behera

By the very mention of the name of Śrīmad Abhinavagupta, two books suddenly appear in the minds of the readers, Dhvanyālokalocan, a commentary on the Dhvanyāloka, and Abhinavabhāratī, a commentary on the Nāṭyaśāstra. That great

ācārya attained fame as a distinguished ācārya of the Tantrāgama tradition. Beyond that, He is also worshiped as a Siddha-ācārya in the Kāshmir-śaiva-āgama or in the Trika-āgama. He had written about forty works based on the principles of tantra and āgama, and everywhere he had explained or achieved the doctrine of śivādvaita (non-dual saivism) with various proofs. Many of his various works are outdated and only a few are available today. The ācārya, pointing out the distinctiveness of the Trikāgama, mentions:

Vedācchaivam tato vāmaṁ tato dakṣaṁ
tataḥ kulam ।

tato mataṁ tataścāpi trikaṁ sarvottamaṁ
param

॥1

There is no insult to the Vedas and others to be understood here by this śloka or verse. Rather, the ācārya wrote this verse to show that, among the paths of mokṣa or the path of achieving Śivādvaita, trikāgama is more important than Vedas and others.

There, in his own Tantrāgama texts, the ācārya discusses the subject of words, which is equivalent to the grammarians. Proofs of perfection or authenticity of Abhinavagupta in his knowledge of grammar is found in the book Śrīpratyabhijñāvivṛtivimarśinī:

Purṇavyākraṇavagāhanaśūciḥ.2

1 Parātrimśikā page- 144

2 Śrīpratyabhijñāvivṛtivimarśinī, Part -1, page- 2.

Also, in the last chapter of Tantrāloka –
pitṛa sa śabdagahane kṛtasampraveśaḥ.3

He, who has studied the entire grammar from his father and has entered the depth of science of word / grammar. This description cannot be made for any general grammarian. Even more evidence can be found in the word structures used in his works and in the grammatically accepted principles. Now, the concepts related to the elements of semantic relationships are being presented.

The essence which is asserted in the law of grammar as word (śabda), meaning of word (artha) and relationship between words and meanings (sambandha) is here considered as Vācya, Vācaka & Adhyāsa. Indeed, considering that grammar is originated from Lord Shiva, and since all knowledge that comes from the mouth of Lord Shiva is in the form of Āgama, the followers of the Āgama prove that grammar is also Āgama.

Acārya Bharṭṛ hari, one of the great grammarians also mentions in his own grammatical and philosophical work Vākyapadīyam as Āgama:

“praṇīto guruṇāsmākam ayam
āgamasamgrahaḥ.”⁴

Just as grammarians assert the eternity of a
word by the vartika sutra

siddheśabdārthasambandhe,⁵

by asserting the eternity of words, their
meanings and their relationship, here the
doctrine of non- dual-word, nothing is
separated from word,
(śabdabrahmādvaitavāda) works. Similarly,
in the Āgamas and Tantras it is said that
nothing is separated from Śiva, that’s
called non-dual shaivism- śivādvaitavāda.
As Śiva is the cause of all illusion of the
form of the universe, the followers of the
Āgamas prove the eternity of all word-
vācaka, meaning-vācya, and relationship of
word and meaning- adhyāsa.

3 tantrāloka 37th āhnika

4 vākyapadīyam 2/487

5 mahābhāṣya paspaśāhnika

meaning too, or the reflection of words
itself is the reflection of meaning. For
the knowledge of
meaning, knowledge of

words does not require a fixed pre-
existence. Knowledge of words does not
precede knowledge of meanings, but
knowledge of words is absolute. At the
same time, they become known. If
knowledge of words exists only before
knowledge of meaning, then relativity
would also be attained and word couldn’t
be known as absolute. Thus, the word is
reflector of itself and its own meaning.
Therefore, the word is taken to be

meaningful - na hi
vācyavācakāgame

śabdavimarśanapūrvakamarthavimarśanamit i

tatrāpi sāpekṣatādi

bhavediti | na hi

śabdavimarśanādaparamarthavimarśanam kiñcit
śabdasya svaparavimarśanatvāt.⁶

The two forms of words are known: the descriptive
word in the form of sound heard and the inner
meaning perceived in the intellect. Grammarians
call sphoṭa, a word that is captured in the intellect.
The user uses the audible sound in the form of a
word, targeting the same inner sound in the
intellect. These sounds which are made up of
words, convey the meaning of the word to the
listener's mind. That verbal meaning evokes the
corresponding meaning in the intellect of the
listener. Indeed, this proves that sound is not only
the sounds heard, but also the inner sound in the
intellect. Reflection is the nature of sound, which is
inter-expressive, and that sound is independent of
signs

The word reflects itself and word’s

PratyavamarśaścaAntarābhilāpātmakaśabdana
svabhāvaḥ,taccaśabdanamśamketanirapekṣam⁷

The basic character of the word is initially a single
and undivided inner-sound, that’s called Nāda.

6 īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivimarśinī Part-3, page-
104

7 īśvarapratyabhijñāvimarśinī, Part-1, page. 303

8 tantrāloka 5/131, viveka commentary of Jayarat

That nāda is transformed into outer-sound, it is stated in the vivekavyākhyā of ācārya Jayaratha of the Tantrāloka that, this unaffected sound becomes the meaning of the word (varṇa) and varṇa is originated from the nāda-

yo'sauanāhatarūpo nādaḥ varṇotpattikāraṇād
varṇaśabdābhidheyo bhavaṭītyarthaḥ8.

In this single nāda, all divided outer words are present undividedly. This means that the sound always remains in the rising state and never sets. Because it is unsettling and remains untouched-

ekonādātmakaḥvarṇaḥ
sarvavarṇāvibhāgavān ।

so'nantamitarūpatvādanāhata ihoditaḥ ॥9

(The one sound-based character nāda is divided into all characters. That, being of infinite and immeasurable form, is here described as unaffected.)

This is the root sound, or nāda, is the god in the form of word residing in the chest of the living entities. And no one else is able to pronounce it. It is also described in the same verse that the supreme god, in the form of varṇa, speaks Himself. The description that this is situated in the chest of living beings is also grammatically acceptable. Grammarian also proclaim śabda brahma or śabdaḥvr śabha as being situated in the chest. The mantra from Ṛgveda-

catvāri śṛṅgāḥ trayo asya.....tridhā baddho
vṛṣabho roravīti10”

There is a śloka in the Tantrāloka also -

So, what is the expressive meaning or Vācyārtha? The Vācyārtha is the mental

nāsyoccārayitā kaścitpratihantā na vidyate ।
svayamuccarate deva prāṇīnāmurasi sthitaḥ
॥11

9 tantrāloka 6/217

10 mahābhāṣya paspaśāhnika, catvārī, in description

of purpose of why study grammar.

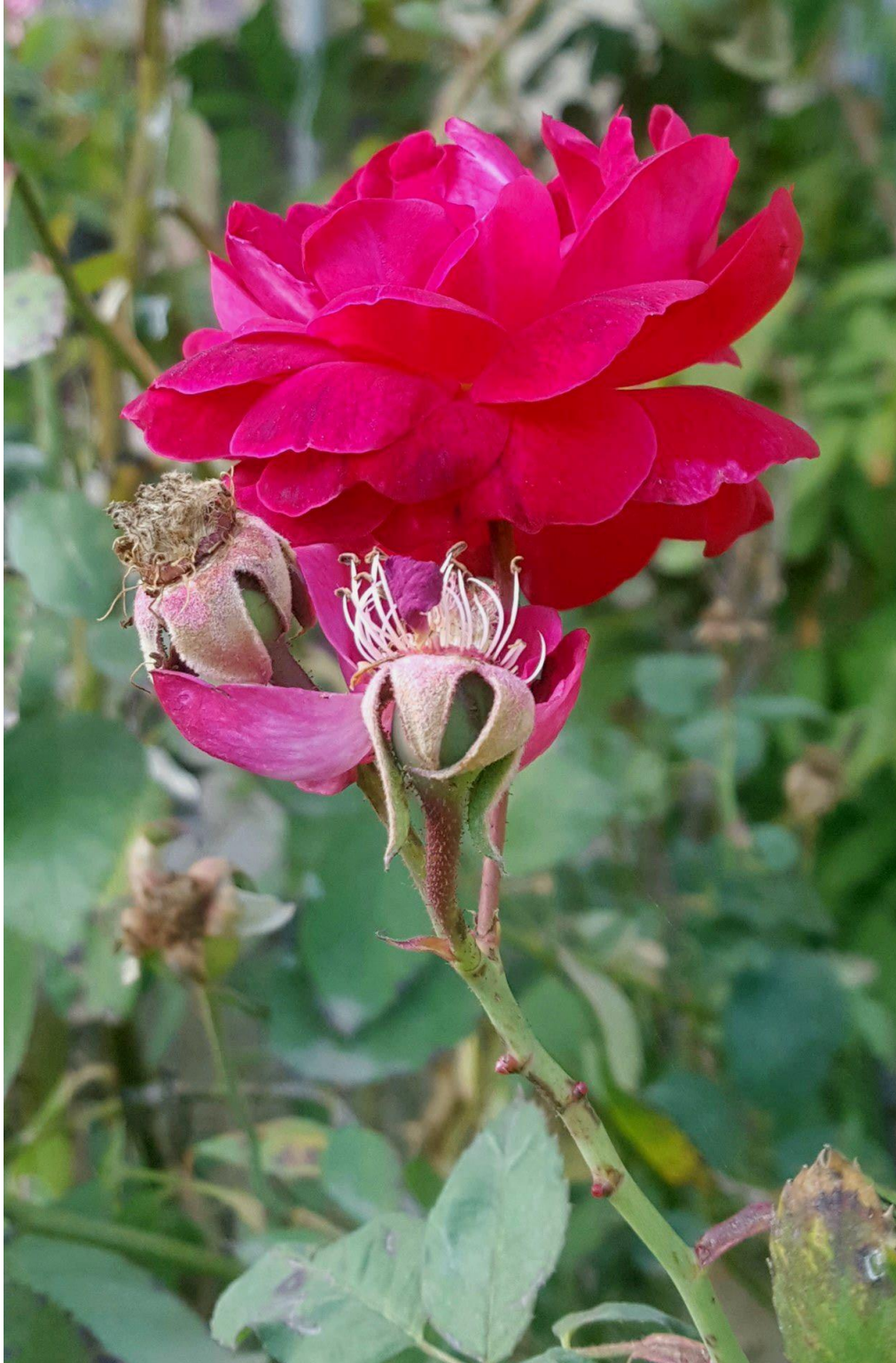
11 Tantrāloka 7

(There is no one who can utter it and no one who can prevent it, the word uttered itself by living in chest of living beings.)

When the same word is pronounced by different speakers and in different contexts, in what sense does the denoting word become descriptive. It is said that the signifier of a word is in its general form. The descriptiveness of a word is proved by the similarity perceived in it, even when pronounced by different speakers and in different types. Linguists express this same principle by the word phoneme, which is common form of words. If the same ka- kāra (word) is pronounced by ten or more speakers, the same shape as ka is perceived in the ten ka- kāra sounds, even when they are heard differently. This is the general relationship between the speaker and the listener with the inner sound - śabdaśca ābhāsāntaraiḥ deśakālādirūpairanāmṛṣṭe ekatraiva ābhāsamātre pravartate.12

image of an object or substance of its own characteristic form in the external. By the

external object, the expressive meaning takes on its specific form, or by the external object like Pot (ghaṭa) the expressive meaning of the intellectual object takes on its form



So, what is the expressive meaning or Vācyārtha? The Vācyārtha is the mental image of an object or substance of its own characteristic form in the external. By the external object, the expressive meaning takes on its specific form, or by the external object like Pot (ghaṭa) the expressive meaning of the intellectual object takes on its form. Where there is no objective existence of the verbal meaning, the imagination alone determines the specific form, for example, the horn of a rabbit (śaśaviṣaṇa), like the son of a barren woman (bandhyāputra). Because of the relationship between the external object and the meaning of the word, the characteristics of the external object are imposed to the meaning of the word in the intellect. The fixed form of this verbal meaning is determined by the mind of the proof or by internal consultation. Again, this fixed form of verbal meaning is suitable for use. For example, the mental image of a pot object, the form of the

meaning of the pot (ghaṭa) word, is determined in the form of fixed characters such as gh-a-ṭ-a (p-o-t). The same can be said by determining the fixed form of the meaning of speech in accordance with the alphabet. Even its indefinite form must be a fixed form: if it is meant by the word i-d-a-m (T-h-i-s), without fixed alphabetical form, nothing can be expressed -

Nahiarthagatād svabhāvda abhilāpavatt
āmanubhavasya ācakṣmahe viṣayapakṣe
abhilāpabhāga. apitu

manaskāramāhātmyāditi ākūtaśeṣaḥ.13

Just as grammarians consider two entities of verbal meaning - the main entity and the formal entity, Ācārya Abhinavagupta has asserted two entities of verbal meaning - the mental entity (Mānasikasattā) and the object entity (vastusattā) in his Tantra and Trika texts. The descriptive word or vācaka is related to the mental entity. It is mental reflection, that is imposed on external objects. The descriptive word, on the other hand, is necessarily associated with the expressive word-

12 Īśvarapratyabhijñānavimarśinī, Part- 2, page- 75

13 Īśvarapratyabhijñānavivṛtivismarśinī, Part- 2, page- 224-25

abhilāpasādhāraṇaśca abhilāpena saha tasya yaḥ
prathate, so'bhilāpasamvalita iti yāvat¹⁴ . The
descriptive word is expressed or expanded in
combination with the imaginative form taken in the
mind. Then objects such as pots and other objects
that are externally present do have meaning, and
those objects are not externally presents also get
their meaning, like Sky_flower- sā ca
khaṇuṣpādīkamapi vyāpnoti ¹⁵

In trikāgama, when it comes to determining the meaning of the preceding fixed characters, the term called compilation and research is introduced (saṁkalanānusandhānākhyam). The listener perceives the various pieces of sound separately through the sense of hearing, connects the pieces of sound perceived by the sense of

14 ĩśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivimarśinī, Part-
3, page- 78

15 ĩśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivimarśinī, Part-
1, page- 259



hearing in different ways with each other by electrical motion. Compilation is the fixed understanding of sound fragments connected by electrical motion with determining their meaning –

Thus, the imposition itself is called adhyasa. That is why the behavior of the world is accomplished by this imposition or relation. There is no unity in reality, and it is perceived by this imposition as

sadasadanekavarṇaviṣayam, anuvyavasāyar
ūp
am, pūrvavarṇasaṃskārāntyavarṇānubhavaj
a nyam saṃkalanajñānam saṃkalanam. 16

16 śrī śrī parātrimśikāyām page- 112

Grammarians also suggest the
same, they described in their
vākyasphoṭa theory as -
pūrvapūrvapadānubhajanitasamskārasahakṛ
ta-antypadaśravaṇadvārā-
anekapadāvagāhinīmānasī-vākyapratīti.

17 īśvarapratyabhijñānavimarśini, Part-1, page- 303

18 īśvarapratyabhijñānavivṛtivimarśini, Part- 2, page-
266

The use of speech is possible only by the
imposition of the signifier word on the
signified meaning or by vice-versa. That is
what is said:

vaktiārtham, svādhyāsenā
so'yamityabhisamdhānena 17

This is the imposition of a word to the
meaning of speech first perceived in the
intellect, and the imposition of the meaning
of speech to an external object such as a
pot. Sound then makes the external form of
a pot and other objects as if they were
sound and makes itself as if it was
objective-

tena parāmarśāvasare
śabdaḥ śabdanarūpatām
gato'rthamapi bahiṣprakāśamānam
ghaṭa itī
tanmayīkurvannātmānam vastumayamiva
vastu ca sātmamayamiva saṃpādayati
tathāpi ca bahiṣprakāśabhūmau
taylorabhedādeva adhyāsavayahārah,
anyathā ātyantike aikye katham
tadvayahārah. 18

one even in difference. This difference should be understood by the Sanskrit word used here - iva. In this way, imposition or Adhyāsa, makes the entire external world seem to be sound.

All the behaviors or uses of the words are possible because of imposition. Just as hearing a descriptive word perceives the underlying meaning in the intellect, so seeing the external object attached to the expressive meaning perceives the underlying denoting word. This is not only in the case in vaikharī, but also in the middle one (madhyamā), where there is a relationship of imposition between the verbal and the descriptive. And that is in the intellect.

When, the mantras uttered in the intellect for the sake of Pujā, in the act of abhichāra and other rituals, there may be no such thing in the external sense, if the attribution or imposition is not between inner-word/madhyamā and outer-world. Without imposition, the use of a word-based mantra, cannot prevail any external meaning- madhyamā tāvat..... vācye vācakam, tatrāpi vācyam

adhyasyate viśvatra
| vācye viśvātmani

vācakamapi viśvātmaiva- tadaiva
parasparācchādanam

lolībhāvātmani nirvahed
adhyāsaḥ, na tvanyathā¹⁹

The word appears in the the I-ness or in the self of Lord Śiva. Because of adhyāsa, this-ness (idantā) of meaning imposed on I-ness (ahantā) word. Ahamnta is supreme form, that cannot be used. Idantā is the for that is being used in this visual and verbal world. Because of imposition or adhyāsa, it is

possible to receive word as this-ness, usable. Otherwise, it would not be possible to use the descriptive I-ness word as this-ness. Intellect is only object of I-ness descriptive word. Therefore, when the meaning of the word is imposed on word, then the word becomes usable. This also demonstrates the importance of adhyāsa.

19 Śrī śrī parātrimśikā pg. 237 | samānameva

varṇanam prāpyate -

īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinyām, Part-2, page-260 |

There is no contradiction in the view that grammarians and Āgamas believe that the root of meanings and words is Parā vāk. She is the goddess in the tradition of the Agama, and her expansion is this visible dual world. At the time of destruction, the entire universe is absorbed in that Goddess Parā vāk. All speech, which is distinctive and dual in form of words and meanings, merges in the supreme form of indifference or non-dual word. That is Parā vāk.²⁰ This supreme speech goddess is the form of Shakti, and the powerful Lord Shiva is the Supreme Lord- śaktayo'sya jagatsarvaṃ śaktimāṃstu maheśvaraḥ. This universe is composed of the power/ vimarśa of Lord Śiva. There, too, the power of Lord Shiva in the form of light is the source of speech. The power, vimarśa or śakti is not separated from lord Śiva, actually Śiva & sakti are non-dual, both are one. Therefore, the four divisions of speech, namely, parā - paśyantī, madhyamā and vaikharī, remain integrally in the Self of Lord Śiva. The words, meanings and relationship between words and meanings, are not different from the essence of speech. Therefore, this is also proved that the relationships between words and meanings are not different Vimarśa. This also proves that they are not different from Lord Śiva. In this way, like Śiva, the whole of speech, which is the subject of words and meanings, are eternal.

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Measuring Meditational Trance



Bhoomi Sati

Meditation is said to help individuals seek a calm, focused, and relaxed state of mind. Various benefits of meditation practices have been established in affective and cognitive processes. There are, nevertheless, a wide range of meditation practices-activities that make up the collection of practices used in the training of positive qualities in the mind and in the developing insight into how the mind-body functions.

Scientifically, such effects can be quantified through the study of brainwaves, or electrical activity in the brain correlating with different states of consciousness. Using various types of equipment, such as an electroencephalogram (EEG), researchers are able to detect changes in brainwave patterns during meditation. For example, while a person is meditating, certain types of brain waves-theta and delta-will begin to predominate, reflecting deeper relaxation and mental quiet.

Open Monitoring (OM) and Focused Attention (FA) are two popular meditation methods. FA is a technique for improving attention that involves concentrating on a single object or feeling, like breathing. This includes techniques like mantra meditation and Himalayan yoga. On the other hand, OM, which is used in practices such as Zen and Vipassana, entails fostering awareness without focussing on any one thing by non-judgmentally observing thoughts and feelings.

FA improves mental clarity and focus, whereas OM fosters non-reactive awareness and broader attention. Despite the fact that the two strategies overlap, OM provides for a more focused approach. It has been

demonstrated that both enhance cognitive conflict resolution, emotion regulation, and attention control (Lippelt et al., 2014; Tang et al., 2015). The aim of transcendental meditation (TM) is to focus on thoughts and sensations aside from distractions by utilising a mantra. On the other hand, loving-kindness (LK) meditation has been connected to enhanced empathy and emotional regulation and encourages compassion, especially towards enemies (Vago & Silbersweig, 2012).

Studies using functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI) have demonstrated that different forms of meditation stimulate distinct parts of the brain, such as the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC), insula, and prefrontal cortex (PFC). Notably, various regions are targeted by different meditation approaches. In contrast to open monitoring (OM), focused attention (FA) increases activity and connectivity in the ACC (Lazar et al., 2000; Botvinick et al., 2004; Manna et al., 2010). FA also exhibits a pattern not seen in OM, including increased activity in the right dorsolateral PFC and higher connection to the right insula (D'Esposito, 2007). Furthermore, when doing activities that emphasise internal bodily feelings (interoception) as opposed to exterior awareness, both FA and OM exhibit enhanced fMRI signals in the posterior insula (Farb et al., 2013). Moreover, various types of meditation improve communication.

EEG and neurofeedback approaches are widely used by researchers to clinically quantify meditational trance, namely the impact of theta and delta waves. These approaches enable real-time observation and study of brain activity during meditation, providing vital insights into how different states of awareness alter brainwave patterns.

EEG is a non-invasive method for recording electrical impulses from the brain. Certain patterns of brainwaves appear during meditation. 4–8 Hz theta waves are linked to deep relaxation, creative thought, and trance-like states. More advanced phases of meditation tend to feature these waves more prominently. Experienced meditators report seeing delta waves (0.5–4 Hz), which are typically associated with deep sleep, during extended periods of peaceful and healing awareness (Tarrant, 2020).

By providing meditators with real-time feedback on their brainwave activity, neurofeedback expands on

EEG. This input, which can be either visual or audible, aids practitioners in controlling their own brain activity. People can achieve a deeper state of meditation by concentrating on raising theta and delta waves while reducing distractions, which are frequently connected to beta waves, which are linked to active thought. Research indicates that elevating alpha (8–12 Hz) and theta waves while decreasing beta waves promotes mental calmness and concentration (Larios et. al. 2020). Cross-frequency coupling—a term used to describe the dynamic interaction between several brainwave frequencies during meditation—has also been highlighted by recent study. For instance, the way that alpha and theta waves interact during meditation illustrates how to strike a balance between increased awareness and relaxation. This relationship implies that meditation influences not just individual brainwave patterns but also the general synchronisation and communication between many brain areas.

By better understanding how meditation affects brain activity, these techniques help develop more effective meditation techniques that increase mental clarity, relaxation, and self-awareness.

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**VERSES ON SHUNYA BY ANDREI
AZSACRA**



THE WAR OF SHUNYA IN JAPAN 0.

Is everything an illusion? 1.

In tender

fluttering of the butterfly is — the Art of War.

2.

Sword of the locust

**are protruding of a belly is reminding of hara-
kiri**

3.

Is squeezed the Emperor's

silk; is crumpled the embroidered dragons.

4.

Die, chrysanthemums!

**The world is under the reign of the diving
bumble-bee.**

5.

Gust of the wind!

One dandelion captures the whole field.

TENDERNESS OF GOD

Survival Denies Preservation 1

It's Cruel Snow

6.

Watch out —

in the tear of kamikaze is — tsunami!

7.

Is squeezed the Emperor's

silk; is crumpled the embroidered dragons.

4.

Die, chrysanthemums!

**The world is under the reign of the diving
bumble-bee.**

5.

Gust of the wind!

One dandelion captures the whole field.

6.

Watch out —

in the tear of kamikaze is — tsunami!

7.

The triumph of

the Burning of the butterflies it is the Empire!

8.

Go away, Emperor!

The butterflies are coming to their Pure Fire.

0.

Everything is an illusion,

but an illusion isn't everything,

but only you

But Not The Sun

That Fondles Feathers Of The Bird —

The She-wolf — Led By The Fire That Burns Madly Quickens Her run

It's Only Possible To Die

Without Cry But Full Of Power —

Small Copper Change Is Hid And Covered

By Scattered Diamonds

It's Only Possible To Kill

The Reason of Being And Of Aim — He Who Will Shoot Himself In Head Of Thrill Will Tear The Thread.

2

Half-Open Are The Eyes Of Blaze But Rage Of Day Does Not Abate — The Hawk Of Vengeance Flies Away

To Count The Righteous

And Replete.

The Unity Of Owls And The Moon — The Eyes See Light In Their Blindness —

And Slowly Is Reduced To Ashes By The Fire

The Eagles' Blood.

For Kiss There Is A Bite And Death — To Feel The Pain The Birds Will Fly —

And Wolves — The Killers That Are Wise

Will Force

The Weak

To Die.

3

Fall Asleep At The End Of The Day — The Moon Turns The Way Into Ashes —

In The Ominous Play Of The Flame

There Is Nothing But God's Tenderness

There Is Nothing But Reinforced Purity — What Love Forbids Is Defied —

It Is Darkness In Its Fury

That Saves

The Light

It Is The Wisdom Of The Slayer

That Strives The Living To Unravel — He Who Tomorrow The Truth Will Reveal Is Bound To Die Today.

4 Death

Creating The Beauty

Will Always

Will Always Overcome —

And What Is Really Red Like Blood Will Shine And Shimmer Bright

What's Really — Really Black
Will Keep The Thrill Inside —
Every Innocent Hides
The Evil And Rebellious
It's Tenderness That Calls

So Frozen In The Deathlike Fire By The Wing
The Birds Are Silently Flying — 7
And In The Center Of Outlined Range The Harmony And Blood Are Bound —
Still Furious You, Eagles Live To Hunt —
They Alight. The Arrow Is Touched by The Palm —

And Freezes
The Whirlwind Of The Snow Again The Feverish Body.
Makes Deathly Purity Attractive —
You Are Whose Truth Is Nowhere The Blade Is Touched By The Palm
You Are Whose Sense Is To Make The Revelation Bright —
To Attack. And Birds of Predatory Psalms

Fly High And Cry.

You'll Have The Sun All To Yourselves —
But Shadows Of The Moon Fly High — The War Is Always Summing Up —
And Claws So Tenderly Will Touch For Love There's No Perfection —
My Lips Let Us Forget The Heavenly Attractions

6 THE CRUELTY IS

Him Who Has Unleashed The War TENDERNESS
Killing Never Pangs — OF GOD.
All Money's To The Flare Thrown
To Let The Fire Reign THE HARMONY OF PEN AND SWORD

The Summit of the Poetry

And Females Are Given To Males will always be
To Feel The Joy Of Copulation — the chopped off
For Beauty And For Revelation head of Yukio
A Temple From Skulls Mishima ...
Is Made.

The harmony of
pen and sword is —
not for weak and

timid
poets ...

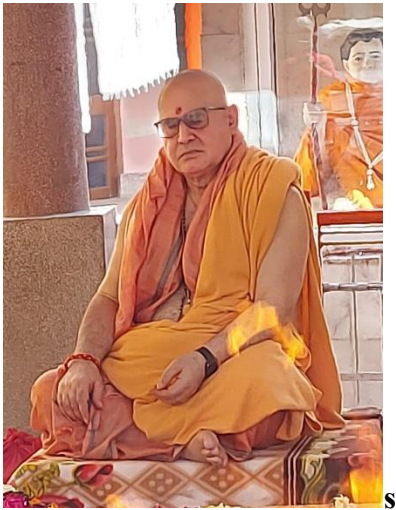
Basho is — not enough,
Byron has — lost the Void,
Rimbaud has — not finished Dao,
and even Eliot himself is —
nothing compared to
Nothing of
Mishima ...
Only Ezra Pound,
from his Divine Cage,
smiles holy and
salutes the
chopped off head ...

All the Best to You,
Brotherly,
Azsacra!

(Andrei Azsacra is a Russia-born esoteric philosopher, novelist, poet, film director and ambient/mantra musician. His novels have been published in India, Tibet, Japan, Germany, Norway, England and USA. He has developed the concept of —Shunya-Revolution‡ . He is also Editorial Advisor for the international journal of poetry and art —Harvests of New millennium‡.)



Physics versus metaphysics (Correspondence between Dr.Sisir Roy and Paranand Swami)



Respected Swamiji,
Niraj Kumar told me about you and your writings in the News Letters.

I am delighted to read some of your articles on Rhythm, cosmic Dance etc".

I tried to communicate to you through gmail but bounced. I requested Niraj to talk to you regarding some matter related to "vibration" or "spanda" from scientific point of view which I have already written in my last mail..

Since vibration cannot be thought of as a-temporal or a-spatial and without the existence of the medium, we scientists face the problem of understanding.

I will be delighted if you enlighten me in this regard.

Warm regards,

Sisir roy

Swamiji's first response is missing

Dr. Roy:

Respected Swamij,

I am delighted to get your response. However, the issue is precisely the following :

(1) The concept "Spanda" seems to be a kind of "vibration " of "kincit chalan" a throbbing. This creates the phenomenal world. This has a striking similarity with the concept of fluctuation of quantum vacuum.

Swamiji's reply:

There is an interesting resemblance between ancient orthodox definition of Spanda and your specification . We consider spanda as a sentient vibrant entity which pervades or rather embraces the entire universal

phenomena and at the same time transcends it . This is similar to the mind charge that quantum physicists recently observed within quantum vacuum.

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयंति जगति सा शांकरी स्पंदशक्तिः

The author of Spanada Karika defines spanda while felicitating it ,as Shiva power of oscillation . Now given that shiva is comparable to quantum vacuum I.e the zone of zero objectivity, then Shakti or to be more precise Spanda Shakti of shiva is the primordial divergent creative impulse that manifests in the form of three conditionings viz Time ,Space and Substance continuum . I have added substance or वस्तु to this continuum because in our ancient canons the infinite as subjective consciousness has three-fold conditioning or अनंत as conditioned in time is called eternity or absolute time . Ananta can also be defined as subjectively conscious quantum vacuum with zero objectivity. This on being conditioned in space is defined as अखण्ड or the spatial substratum . The absolute universal principle as per the Upanishadic power and process of universal manifestation generates grosser material manifestation of ether ,air ,fire water and earth and then pervades these in such a manner that he interlaces these without any actual modification . Then there is the process of divergence according to the attributes of these five basic constituents of the universal phenomena namely sound as that of the ether sound and touch as the attributes of air ,sound ,touch and sight of fire and sound ,touch ,sight ,and taste as the four attributes of water .

Your hunch or let's call it intuitive insight just falls in with such notions in our ancient revelations regarding space-time continuum. Besides these two the third "Substance- conditioning " of the absolute principle is also considered in our ancient texts . Space or Akash in its subtlemost form is not just a medium which might as well be absent in the parlance of quantum vacuum but the space transcendent subjectively conscious substratum . Shiva as the guru or supreme preceptor has been felicitated as व्योमवत् व्याप्त देह I.e. Manifesting as the omnipresent ether or चिदाकाश . As per the notion of chidakash it must pervade even quantum dot or quantum vacuum which as I figure out is the line of demarcation between actual and intellectual notion . Substance is added as the third condition since the original subtle notion of ether is akin to what quantum science understands as quantum vacuum . We have a description of five gradations of subtlety in the tantric canons .Being the subtlest and most pervasive ether is contained in solid ,fluid,energy ,and dynamic manifestation of nature the fifth form of Akash is called

(चिदाकाश) or conscious ether .This is the twilight zone of mind matter juncture .

The gross ether as a part of the gross penta-dimensional phenomena ,the subtler ether as subtler ether that pervades the rest of the four elements ,chittakash or the ether that pervades individual intelligence comprising cognitive,volition,imaginative and self determining faculties . The subtle most or chidakash or conscious ether exhibits similar characteristics of QV . If this चिदाकाश by any stroke of chance turns out be also pervading quantum vacuum owing to space transcendent nature of the both then mind and energy as the primordial building brick of the universal phenomena can be consistent from either perspective I.e physical as well as spiritual .

Dr.Roy : Why this fluctuation in vacuum ? We assume that Quantum Principle is valid everywhere - not only in phenomenal world. So according to Heisenberg Uncertainty principle, there will be enormous fluctuation of energy during a very short period of time.

Swami Ji's reply

Heisenberg is right in his own place but is this just an arbitrary behaviour of insentient matter or the design of highly ingenious nature of the supreme being ?

The agency that accounts for this fluctuation or let's say spanda in the eternal still quietude of the sentient ether or cidakash is in fact the process of Shiva manifesting as Shakti. This divergent outflux or spandanam is the second succession of modification, the first being the atman creating ether the second step is air or rit springing forth from the primordial ether.

The nearest parallel of "quantum " in the parlance of consciousness specially when it comes to subjective consciousness has been called sphota स्फोट in our metaphysics .Like energy, consciousness also propagates in the form of small units or packages termed as Quantas and sphota respectively .Ancient seers conceptualised this process as pertaining to expressible word I.e either a syllable or word or sentence .

Energy शक्ति in this context is defined as the power of consciousness that accounts for the relation of word with its meaning . This semblance leads us to the consistency of quantum physics principles in the realm of consciousness .

Awareness as such manifests in the form of word and meaning which are known as nad नाद and बिंदु (nada

being the point of absolute convergence of collective word and Bindu the point of absolute convergence of collective meaning) .Eastern metaphysics emphasises on the Nada aspect whereas modern science focuses on the notion of Bindu, objectively though .

Dr Roy:

(2) Concept of Quantum Vacuum : Various type of fields are there and hence concept of space time is there.

(3) My hunch is that space time itself is generated by this fluctuation.

But we do not really understand this process?

Swamiji's reply

As I have said above your hunch just falls in with the Upanishadic dictum regarding the power and process of the creation or let us say the manifestation of the universal phenomena .

Or? from this self I.e. Pure subjective consciousness ether springs forth from the ether air and from ether air(tattiriya upanisad)

If the ether were to be compared to quantum vacuum then the secondary manifestations air or dynamism and energy follow . The " will to create " interlaces all the following varieties of grosser manifestation . As another Upanishad Antaryami Brahman goes ... “one who interlaces ether knows ether but whose ether doesn't know ,one who indwells air who knows air but whom air knows not”

These are the ultimate postulations by our hoary seers in a parlance of mind matter relationship . We must conceptualise matter as insentient and the underlying streamline of consciousness as pervading various gradations of subtlety and grossness of matter and accounting for their respective characteristics . These are based on intuitive insight and not on scientific observation therefore these are assimilated better through faith and devotion .

Shri Aurobindo writes in his synthesis of yoga – “energy in the power and process of creation is matter and spirit in the power and process of creation is mind” . Off late there has been a sort of innovation in the post shankarite monism to ignore all other schools of thought as meant for less competent and extrovert aspirants . So all talks of insentient matter converting into living protoplasm stand refuted. The conscious substratum must be preconceived which before converting into dynamic perpetuation or spanda out of still a temporal void or vacuum excercises his own free will .

स्वस्मिन् स्वात्म स्वभित्तौ कलयति धरणीमाशिवांतं जगद्वा

हंतानंतस्फुरत्ता जयतिजगति सा शांकरीस्पंदशक्तिः

(propitiatory verse of spand karika)

Within the canvas of her own conscious substratum she creates this universe consisting of thirty six elements from earth to shiva .

From the stand point of quantum physics it IS may be too early to conclude anything but from an eastern metaphysical perspective the divine will of the universal being accounts for this mystic phenomena of spanda .

This is the very nature of the lord but how can a complete and content being have any wish to manifest or procreate?

देवस्यैषस्वभावोयं आप्तकामकामस्य का स्पृहा (Gaud padacharya)

Dr. Roy

(4) May be here lies the mystery of "spanda".

(5) Concept of āṇḍa" or "egg" principle is considered in Indian Philosophy.

I think it is a metaphor - like Hiranyagarbha or "tathagatagarbha" in Lankavatar sutra.

Sometimes I wonder why this metaphor of "garbha" or "womb" was introduced.

Can you enlighten me in these issues ?

Warm regards,

sisir roy

Swamiji's reply

As per the Indian law of causation the effect cannot supersede the cause so even with all its reciprocations the objective phenomena cannot transcend the substratum which is the pure subjective consciousness Which as you define is a temporal and time transcendent entity .

The expanse of the lords vision is same whether the universal phenomena is completely extant or it is when it is dormant in a seed form ,one canon on tantric metaphysics says .Hence the analogy of the yolk of an egg or a womb . The Veda propound an intermediate stage that predates actual creation as hiranyagarbha or the golden womb .

Hiranyagarbha manifested in the beginning The creator of all beings and their lord . He sustained the earth and the heavens ,to him do we offer oblations (rikveda)

When the a priori of creation is an existent entity we call it the golden womb or hiranyagarbha . When the ultimate is required to be pronounced as

essenselessness or nisvabhavata then we call it tathagata garbha . But the basic idea is the same .

The maxim of the yolk of a peahen egg is popular among the Shaivites of Kashmir मयूरांडसन्ध्यायः न्यायः . All colourful beauty of the plumage tuft and feathers of a peacock are dormant in the yolk of its egg . Apparently it looks only a white colour less jelly with a lump of yellow mass . Like wise within the quantum vacuum or perhaps the concept of QCD the chromodynamic blue print of creation may be encrypted in a dormant seed form . The quantum chromodynamics phenomena may be a projection of some more discreet design of future manifestation embedded in the sub nuclear realms . The semiotics of a peahen egg just befits the context .

It would be a great break through if the string theory of electronic physics could be related to the ancient concept of सूत्रात्मा -a fine filament of living energy or प्राण which pervades the individual subtle body and the cosmic subtle body or hiranyagarbha .

I hope this philosophising is of some use to you

Yours in the lord .

Swami paranand tirth .

Dr. Roy's question?????

Swamiji's explanation:

In this particular mantra of Isavasyasyopanisad , Tamsin -within him , refers to the conscious and subjective space or chidakash. This concept falls in with the notion of quantum vacuum except that there is no scientific proof of its being a subjectively sentient entity as of now . There are two entities mentioned in this mantra आप and मातरिश्वा instead of using the dictionary, meaning "water" I chose to define it as "fluidity "dynamic flow which is similar to अप and मातरिश्वा .we have two other Vedic mantras which rule out these two as insentient material entities . One is from Brihadaranyaka it says ता आप ऐक्षत the waters cogitated and another mantra from rikveda containing the term matarishwa which sayanacharya interprets as मातरि आकाशे श्रयति श्रसिति इति

मातरिश्वा (an entity which respire in the conscious ether)

The crux is that both fluidity or aap and dynamism or matarishwa are sentient modifications of a sentient ether or chidakash . No fluctuation or movement can ever exceed the domain of their substratum hence these are contained within it . This is where scientific advancement and mystic insights meet.

My wavelength is more in tune with Upanishadic and tantrik thought therefore I defined aap as fluidity and

matarishwa as dynamism. the primordial divergent flutter or spanda may be reflected in the phenomena that accounts for the manifestation of electrical charge (aap and matarishwa) in quantum vacuum.

The other day I was watching a video of group discussion ,One eminent scientist called all this "spoof-physics " being construed to vindicate hackneyed metaphysics, This doesn't have to be so with ingenious scientists like you who also have a bent for our metaphysical heritage . And therefore also trying to tie up the loose ends accordingly .

Yours in the lord

Swami paranand tirth .

Dr. Roy:

Respected Swamiji,

I am delighted to get your response regarding the meaning of the word

"maatarisva" in Mantra 4 of Isopanisad.

You say :vacuum is fluid dynamic.

This is very interesting from the point of view of modern physics.

In modern cosmology we say that the universe is originated from the fluctuation of Quantum vacuum.

Now when you say fluid dynamic : why you say fluid instead of saying simply space;

If we decompose this word into two parts : maatri and svas ;

maatri is related to mother means measure. So we can say space is the substratum of measure or distance because unless there is measure or simply distance. you can not create any form.

One can think of the principle of Maya at the very beginning also. Again the word maya is related to ma or to measure. Whenever you say measure, it means limitation and hence illusion created about the ultimate reality. I read somewhere that "maatarisva" means space which breathes i.e. in our terminology we say fluctuation of space.

Why this fluctuation - because of the existence of Heisenberg uncertainty principle in quantum theory.

According to this principle, during very short duration of time, there will be huge fluctuation of energy which gives rise to the universe.

Now very interesting question comes :

Whether space itself fluctuates or the existence of certain kind of fluctuation of fluid, makes the space fluctuation occur.

I will be delighted if you explain me why you choose fluid.

Warm regards,

sisir roy

Swamiji:

Blessed self

I have also included the word अपः that precedes matarishwa . Both have

A special type of dynamism is common I.e. A temporal displacement .

Fluid, as one of my dictionaries defines it is a substance subject to continuous deformation under some pressure or force . Vayu or spirit has no form and flows continuously motivated by the power of will or action or knowledge .ज्ञान इच्छा and क्रिया , so I thought fluid and fluidity was more conveying . If one reflected on the first half of the mantra

तद्भावतो अन्यान्यत्येति तिष्ठन् it tells us about the fluctuation within the substratum of a static vacuum . An extra temporal displacement !

I deliberately chose the term fluid or Fluidity because it denotes primordial movement in the still and stagnant ether or to be more precise the conscious ether .In the arcane tantrik ontology this is defined as Shakti tatvan. The. Just movement cannot explain any supra temporal displacement .

This is more efficaciously explained in Pratyabhijna Hridayam.

Sacred Lodge for Beloveds
~ Ambika Talwar



Sacred lodge cannot be dimmed
by a passing glance, but for a cosmic moment
desires arise — Well water's pure stream
sings through fire rising mist in valleys.

Songs that have lain low lift as tho' heaven
were no ceiling but pages scrambled
with music of love that cools the fire
and heats it up streaming into our hearts.

Where sacred lore weaves its nadis
into Gaia's arteries, heaven awakens
for lovers have resided amid broken rocks.

Wherever Sati's body pieces were thrown
is a temple to Mother; each particle we breathe
is temple of Her limbs, eyes, nabhi, yoni
her pithas are splendid cushions of rock
Rest here in your sufferings... Place of refuge.

Grace that delights is not lost in the sanctum:
bee-hives are woven with hearts, hands, hair

eyes of dove, deer, pelican, eagle, peacock,
remind us again how circles entwining hum-sa
open doors so we may never be lost.
Blow your breath into my breath! Be a crucible.
Wink madly as if intoxicants knew no way out.

Sing wildly! Let winds circle madly
Call loudly madly for Ma. How can she ignore
her own longing for rivers to curl on our palms?

Oh Heart! Be endless doors Invisible
and indivisible as eternal Beloved

(Ambika Talwar is an India-born author, poet, wellness consultant, artist, and educator whose vision is to realize her sacred destiny and invite others to brilliance. She has authored *4 Stars and 25 Roses* (poems for her father) and *My Greece: Mirrors & Metamorphoses* about her travels through Greece in 2002.)





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